Athena Swan Ireland Bronze application: Departments

Name of institution	University College Cork
Name of department	School of Computer Science and Information Technology
Date of current application	December 2022
Level of previous award, if applicable	Not applicable
Date of previous award, if applicable	Not applicable
Contact name	Professor John Morrison
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Section	**Words used**
Section 1: An introduction to the department's Athena Swan work	2,401 / 2,000
Section 2: An assessment of the department's gender equality context and, where relevant, wider equality context	7,532 / 8,000
Section 3: Action Plan	N/A
Overall word count	9,933 / 10,000

Typesetting Conventions

Text formatting

Template instructional text is typeset as follows in a sans-serif font, for example:

Provide information on the preparation and delivery of this application by the department. This should include:

- a description of the self-assessment team, including comment on the roles and responsibilities of individuals, and how these were assigned.

Regular text is typeset in a serif font.

Figures and Tables

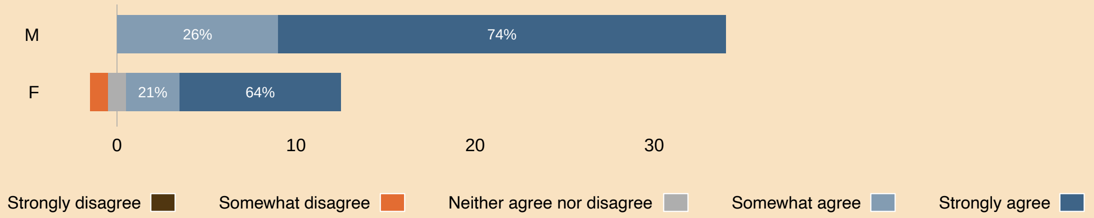
All tables and figures are identified by three-part numbers: the first two parts indicate the section; the third part is a counter within that section. For example, Table 2.1.15 would be the 15th table within Section 2.1. Some tables are zero-inflated; to maintain readability of those tables, zeros are replaced with dashes, for example:

Example Table Example table with many zeros, replaced by dashes

	Permanent/CID			Fixed-Term			
Grade	M	F	%F	M	F	%F	Total
Academics							
Professor	4	-	-	-	-	-	4
Professor (Scale 2)	4	-	-	-	-	-	4
Senior Lecturer	5	-	-	-	-	-	5
Lecturer (above bar)	14	1	6.7%	1	-	-	16
Lecturer (below bar)	-	1	100%	2	1	33%	4

This document contains many figures presenting Likert-scale responses; in cases where the numbers do not fit well, these are filtered out, as in the example figure below.

Example Figure Likert-scale response with filtered numbers



Actions and Priorities

All actions proposed by the School of Computer Science and Information Technology (CSIT) are presented as follows:

ACTION 2.2.1: Recruitment and Unconscious Bias Training for Research Positions

Create a school policy on research recruitment. ☞

Actions are numbered in the same way as figures and tables, explained above. The action number is followed by an action title, which is indexed in the List of Actions on Page xii.

The ☞ icon is a hyperlink that provides quick access to the Actions table in Section 3. To go back to where the action is introduced, a hyperlink is provided in the Actions table.

On occasion, reference is made to Actions proposed by the university in its institutional Athena Swan Bronze Award Action Plan. These are presented as follows:

UCC INSTITUTIONAL ATHENA SWAN BRONZE AWARD ACTION 5.1.3

Establish a promotion pathway to Professor Scale 1, drawing on learnings for gender equality implemented in schemes for promotion to SL (Jan 2019) and Prof Scale 2 (Oct 2019) scheme calls (see Action 5.1.4).

Priorities as set out in Section 2.5 are presented as follows:

PRIORITY 5

Promote a culture of inclusivity and belonging. ☞

The ☞ icon is a hyperlink that provides quick access to the appropriate part of the Actions table in Section 3, listing all actions relevant to that particular Priority.

Contents

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List of Actions

List of Terms and Abbreviations

ADVANCE-CRT	The SFI Centre for Research Training for Advanced Networks for Sustainable Societies
APCD	Academic Programmes and Curriculum Development
AS	Athena Swan
BA	Bachelor of Arts
BADH	BA in Digital Humanities
BAPC	BA in Psychology and Computing
BSc	Bachelor of Science
BScCS	BSc in Computer Science
BScDSA	BSc in Data Science and Analytics
CAS	Central Academic Services
CID	Contract of Indefinite Duration
CIRTL	Centre for Integration of Research, Teaching, and Learning
Confirm	The SFI Research Centre for Smart Manufacturing
Connect	The SFI Research Centre for Future Networks and Communications
CRT	Centre for Research Training
CRT-AI	The SFI Centre for Research Training in Artificial Intelligence
CS	Computer Science

CSIT	School of Computer Science and Information Technology
CSSS	Computer Science Systems Support
DCU	Dublin City University
DEIS	Delivering Equality of opportunity In Schools; a category of schools that meet certain disadvantage criteria, as defined on the Department of Education website: `https://www.gov.ie/en/publication/a3c9e-extension-of-deis-to-further-schools/`
DISC	Disciplines Inquiring into Societal Challenges
DSS	Disability Support Services
EDI	Equality, Diversity, and Inclusion
EDIIC	EDI Implementation Committee
Enable	Science Foundation Ireland Spoke on Smart Communities involving Connect, Lero, and Insight
F	Female
FTE	Full Time Equivalent
HDACT	Higher Diploma in Applied Computer Technology
HE	Higher Education
HEA	Higher Education Authority (Ireland)
HeCoS	Higher Education Classification of Subjects
HESA	Higher Education Statistics Agency (UK)
HoS	Head of School
HR	Department of Human Resources
ICT	Information and Communication Technologies
IHREC	Irish Human Rights and Equality Commission
Insight	Insight SFI Research Centre for Data Analytics
IO	International Office
ISCED	International Standard Classification of Education
iWish	I WISH is a Volunteer led community committed to showcasing the power of Science, Technology, Engineering and Maths to female secondary school students
Lero	The SFI Research Centre for Software
M	Male
MPT	Munster Programming Training
MSc	Master of Science

MScCS	MSc in Computer Science
MScDSA	MSc in Data Science and Analytics
MScIM	MSc in Interactive Media
MU	Maynooth University
OVPRI	Office of the VP for Research and Innovation
PDR	Performance Development Review
PDRS	Performance Development Review System
PGR	Postgraduate Research student
PGT	Postgraduate Taught students
PI	Principal Investigator
PMS	Professional Management and Support
PMSS	Professional Management and Support Staff
SALI	Strategic Academic Leadership Initiative
SAT	Self-Assessment Team
SEFS	Science, Engineering, and Food Science
SFI	Science Foundation Ireland
SIPTU	Services, Industrial, Professional and Technical Union
SL	Senior Lecturer
STEM	Science, Technology, Engineering, and Mathematics
TCD	Trinity College Dublin
TLCF	Third Level Computing Forum
TLSE	Teaching Learning and Student Experience
UCC	University College Cork
UCD	University College Dublin
UK	United Kingdom
WG	Workgroup
WiSTEM	Women in STEM

1

An introduction to the department's Athena Swan work

In Section 1, applicants should evidence how they meet Criterion A:

- Structures and processes underpin and recognise gender equality work and, where relevant, wider equality work

Recommended word count: 2000 words

1 Letter of Endorsement from the Head of School

Insert (with appropriate letterhead) a signed letter of endorsement from the head of the department. The letter should comment on:

- the link between the Athena Swan Ireland principles and the department's strategy;
- leadership of the head of department in advancing equality, including any involvement in the self-assessment or specific actions;
- evidence of how the department's equality work is led and supported by the department's senior management;
- key priorities, achievements and challenges relating to gender equality as discerned from the self-assessment;
- where relevant, key priorities, achievements and challenges relating to additional equality grounds, as discerned from the self-assessment;
- priority actions to address the issues and opportunities identified.

University College Cork, Ireland
Coláiste na hOllscoile Corcaigh

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30 November, 2022

Subject: **Endorsement of Athena SWAN Bronze Award Application**

Dear Dr Fink,

As Head of School of Computer Science and Information Technology (CSIT), I wish to commit my full support to the Athena Swan (AS) Ireland Principles and pledge to imbed these principles into the culture, policies, and practices of the school. In addition to forming an Equality, Diversity, and Inclusivity (EDI) Implementation Committee (EDIIC), each School standing committee will have an Athena Swan Champion; this process will align with the allocation of all school administrative duties.

CSIT is one of the largest schools in the College of Science, Engineering and Food Science (SEFS). It is a multifaceted ecosystem, composed of academics (33, 9% female), professional, managerial and support staff (25, 48% female), research staff (23, 17% female), postgraduate research (45, 13% female), postgraduate taught (129, 46% female) and undergraduate (390, 24% female) students.

Traditionally, Computer Science is a male dominated discipline; our flagship undergraduate programme is 14% female. Recognising this, we previously formed partnerships with Psychology and Digital Humanities and developed two interdisciplinary undergraduate degrees. These have been strategically important initiatives which have increased our female undergraduate numbers (24%). Two female academic staff members have been appointed to teach on, support and develop the gender balance of these programmes.

We started our AS self-assessment in Spring 2021. As Head of School, I appointed

Professor John Morrison as Chair of the Self-Assessment Team (SAT). Appointing a senior experienced leader as Chair of the SAT demonstrates my commitment supporting the adoption of the AS Principles in the school. The SAT was composed of 29 school members, 41% female.

The SAT has identified five priority areas that will be addressed over the next four years.

1. Firstly, we need to develop governance structures, policies and procedures to ensure that the Athena Swan Ireland Principles are embedded in the school. I will address this priority through the establishment of an EDI Implementation Committee, appointing a Chair from senior staff. The committee will have the authority to oversee and implement the action plan.
2. Currently, there is a dearth of female academic (9%) and research (17%) staff particularly at higher grades. Increasing the ratio of female applicants for staff posts in these cohorts is expected to improve the staff gender balance. I will prioritise the development of guidelines to improve the school's gender imagery and advertising, and actively target females encouraging them to apply for academic and research positions whilst providing focused support for female staff in the school.
3. Our aim to increase the number of female students registered in undergraduate and postgraduate programmes will continue through ongoing partnerships with our colleagues in digital humanities and psychology. By understanding our current student's motivation to study Computer Science allows us to develop strategies to improve gender balance in our core CS programmes. We plan to provide a richer experience for our current female students through internships and scholarship, thus providing female role models for future students.
4. In 2023, I will restart the Performance Development and Review Process (PDRS) to improve support for staff development and career progression. Mentors will be appointed to female staff and training, and funding workshops will be arranged to enhance their change of promotion.
5. I am committed to promoting a culture of inclusivity and belonging in the school, and will create a policy defining how the school will implement statutory family leave. I will ensure that students from diverse backgrounds have opportunities to study with us. We will keep in touch with colleagues from other schools, for example through the Third Level Computing Forum (TLCF), to ensure that we are in line with the EDI agenda both nationally and internationally.

To ensure that our actions are having a positive impact and desired effect on the EDI culture, we will conduct a review towards the end of 2026 to evaluate progress and staff and student satisfaction and experience.

The information presented in the application is an honest, accurate and true representation of the school.

Yours sincerely,

Utz Roedig
Professor of Computer Science
Head of School of Computer Science and Information Technology

Confirmation

The information presented in the application (including qualitative and quantitative data) is an honest, accurate and true representation of the department. ☒

2 Governance and recognition of equality, diversity and inclusion work

a Provide a description of the department's structures to advance equality. This should include:

+ information on where the department is in the Athena Swan process;
+ an organigram of the department's key management and/or committee structures, with headcount by gender, that includes the formal reporting structures in place to carry out and support Athena Swan activity and, if applicable, wider EDI work;
+ information on the relationship of department structures with departmental Athena Swan structures and, if applicable, EDI structures, including mechanisms for sharing the findings of self-assessment as well as good practice;
+ information on support provided by the department for the application;
+ information on formal processes in place to resource, distribute, recognise and reward Athena Swan and, where applicable, EDI work, referencing department-level policies where appropriate;
+ resource provision for the action plan and associated activities to ensure effective implementation;
+ any other relevant structure and organisation information, such as the department's relationship with community partners;
+ confirmation that staff and students are recorded as the gender with which they identity in this submission.

Information on where the department is in the Athena Swan process

In response to a call for expressions of interest, the school of School of Computer Science and Information Technology (CSIT) appointed an Athena Swan (AS) Champion in 2019 in recognition of the importance of the Equality, Diversity, and Inclusion (EDI) agenda at university level, to increase awareness and to set the groundwork to prepare for an AS Bronze application. Between 2019 and 2022, the Champion represented the school at the College of Science, Engineering, and Food Science (SEFS), and provided regular updates at school meetings.

A Self-Assessment Team (SAT) was set up in Spring 2021 and all school members were invited to join; the final composition ensured gender representation and role equality among staff and postgraduate students (see Table 1.3.1, Page 10).

This application reports on three years of data, namely from 2017-2020. Data cited in this application have been gathered from a staff survey conducted by the university's

EDI unit in June-July 2021, and three focus group sessions in May-June 2022. Data maintained as part of local CSIT records are also cited to supplement centralised records.

An organigram of the department's key management and/or committee structures, with headcount by gender, that includes the formal reporting structures in place to carry out and support Athena Swan activity and, if applicable, wider EDI work

Table 1.2.1 summarises leadership roles within the school, reflecting a dearth of women in senior academic and research grades. The term "Research Director" in Table 1.2.1 refers to senior director-level roles in one of the multi-institutional national research centres funded by Science Foundation Ireland (SFI) that the school is involved in (Table 2.1.2), and two Centres for Research Training (CRT) for training PhD students, also funded by SFI (Table 2.1.3).

Table 1.2.1 Key roles within CSIT by gender

School Leadership			Research Leadership		
	F	M		F	M
Head of School	0	1	Research Directors⋆	0	4
PMS Managers	1	1	Principal Investigators	0	10
Programme Directors	2	6	SFI Funded Investigators⋆⋆	1	8
Committee Chairs	0	8			

⋆ Director refers to Directors or Co-Directors of SFI Research Centres.
⋆⋆ SFI Funded Investigator (FI) is a role within an SFI Research Centre, such as Connect and Lero; an FI leads one or more research projects within such a centre, and must be approved by SFI.

Figure 1.2.1 shows the gender distribution in school leadership roles. Most staff have administrative responsibilities and serve in school committees. Key academic administrative responsibilities in the school are clearly gender imbalanced. The greatest gender imbalance is in academic staff, particularly at senior level (Figure 1.2.2).

The school has eight committees to support school activities. Table 1.2.2 shows the gender distribution of committee members.

Figure 1.2.1 Overall school management and committee structures / programme directors

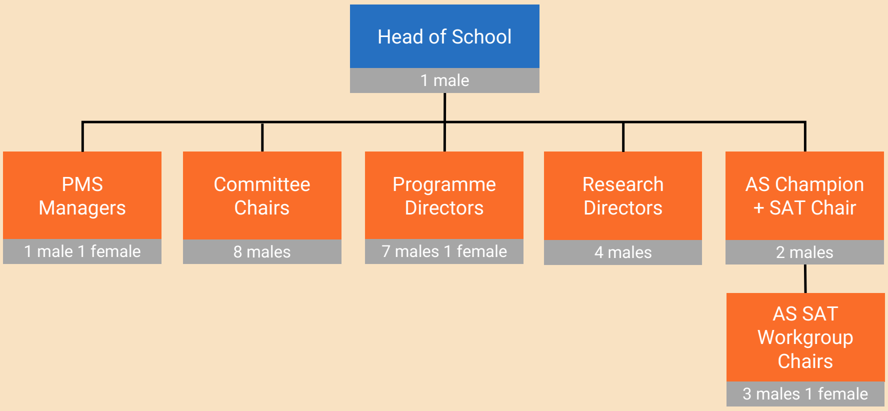


Table 1.2.2 Gender representation in School committees

Role	Male	Female	Female %	Total
Committee Chairs	8	0	0%	8
Committee Members	16	7	30%	23
All Committee (Chairs and Members)	24	7	23%	31

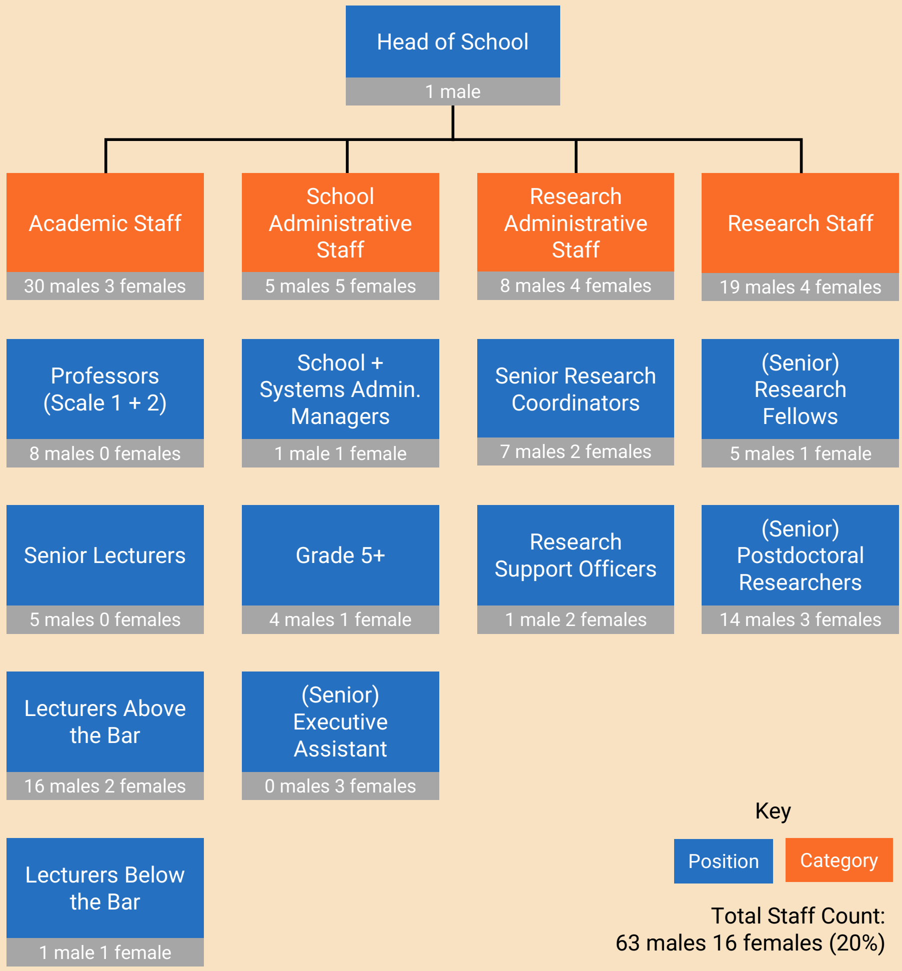
Information on the relationship of department structures with departmental Athena Swan structures and, if applicable, EDI structures, including mechanisms for sharing the findings of self-assessment as well as good practice

The SAT engaged intensively with the university's EDI unit and other schools within the university seeking AS accreditation. It also consulted with colleagues in cognate schools from other universities that had already successfully engaged with the AS process. The SAT Chair regularly reported progress through a standing item on the school's monthly meeting agenda.

Information on support provided by the department for the application

The school provided full administrative support to the SAT in organising meetings and taking minutes. The School Manager coordinated the collection of local data with with the Research Centre administrators and compiled this data into a suitable format for the SAT to review. The Head of School (HoS) actively promoted the SAT activities at

Figure 1.2.2 School staff at CSIT per Autumn 2022



Note: numbers per Autumn 2022; some may differ in other figures and tables.

all school meetings, encouraging staff to take part in discussions and giving adequate time for everyone to comment on the process and findings. In addition, the university provided extensive support to the school during the production of this application. The EDI unit supported in the production, administration and collation of results of the staff survey. In addition, Academic Support Services and HR provided data. Although not required for this application, the university also makes funds available for practical support for AS applications.

Information on formal processes in place to resource, distribute, recognise and reward Athena Swan and, where applicable, EDI work, referencing department-level policies where appropriate

The school recently embarked on its AS journey, so apart from the SAT activities, there are currently no formal processes in place to resource, distribute, or reward AS work. At the school level, AS activities are recognised by the HoS in assigning administrative workload. On appointment, the Chair was relieved of other administrative obligations to concentrate on coordinating the school's AS activities.

Resource provision for the action plan and associated activities to ensure effective implementation

The school has availed of resources provided by the university's EDI unit for the application, including regular feedback and advice from the university's AS Project Officer. It will continue to avail of all centrally available resources to support the implementation of CSIT's Action Plan. The EDI Implementation Committee (EDIIC) will report any resource deficits to the HoS and to the College's AS Steering Committee. Appropriate changes to the school structures will seek to support the implementation of the action plan (Actions 1.3.1 and 1.3.2, Page 18), improving the EDI culture.

Any other relevant structure and organisation information, such as the department's relationship with community partners

Since the school embarked on its AS journey, it has been an active member of the university EDI activities and will benefit from, and contribute to, developing best practice.

Confirmation that staff and students are recorded as the gender with which they identity in this submission

All requests by staff or students to record their gender preference have been acceded to with confirmation by all data holders to record the appropriate gender.

3 The Self-Assessment Process

a Provide information on the preparation and delivery of this application by the department. This should include:

- a description of the self-assessment team, including comment on the roles and responsibilities of individuals, and how these were assigned. The gender of SAT members, their professional/student role in the department, and their specific role in the SAT should be noted in a table;
- information on how the chair was appointed and on what supports or resources the institution and/or department has given the chair to lead the self-assessment process;
- comment on whether the self-assessment team is representative of the department, including if there is adequate representation of senior staff.

A description of the self-assessment team, including comment on the roles and responsibilities of individuals, and how these were assigned. The gender of SAT members, their professional/student role in the department, and their specific role in the SAT should be noted in a table

The initial SAT was appointed in March 2021 after an open invitation by the HoS to all school members. The initial 10 members were a self-selecting group at various stages in their professional careers and included representation from both Professional Management and Support Staff (PMSS) and Academic staff (see Tables 1.3.1).

Table 1.3.1 Initial and expanded SAT: Gender, leadership, and staff category

	Initial SAT April 2021			Expanded SAT December 2021			% by staff category
	M	F	%F	M	F	%F	
Chair	1	0	0%	1	0	0%	n/a
Workgroup Chairs	0	0	0%	3	1	25%	n/a
Academic	3	2	40%	12	3	20%	52%
Professional Management and Support Staff	1	4	80%	3	6	67%	31%
Research staff	0	0	0%	2	3	60%	17%
Total	4	6	60%	17	12	41%	100%

Midway through the application process, a new Athena Swan Charter was published, including a new application form. The SAT responded to these changed by reorganising itself into four thematic Workgroups (WGs) to better match the structure of the new application (see Table 1.3.2). WG Chairs were invited to serve by the SAT Chair, based on their experience in leading teams and knowledge of UCC's institutional structures. WG Chairs were also chosen with the intention of achieving gender balance, although limited by the gender imbalance within the school.

In addition to the four workgroups, a Chair's Workgroup was formed, consisting of the four WG Chairs, the SAT Chair, the School Manager, and the Workgroup Liaison.

Subsequently, more people were invited to join the SAT to maximise representation. This expansion was done by (1) open invitation to all staff, and (2) by targeting specific individuals to maximise diversity and promote inclusion. The SAT members were at various stages in their career, with many of the senior staff having considerable experience in the running of the school and serving on university committees. Table 1.3.3 presents details of all 29 SAT members.

Table 1.3.2 Workgroups and distribution of members by gender and staff category

	Gender		Staff category		
Workgroup	M	F	Academic	PMSS	Research
Chair's Workgroup[1]	5	2	6	1	0
WG1: Department and Its Context	3	1	2	2	0
WG2: Academic and Research Careers	6	3	5	0	4
WG3: Professional, Managerial and Support Staff Careers	3	3	2	4	0
WG4: Inclusion and Belonging	3	3	4	1	1
Administrative support	0	2	0	2	0
Total SAT members (29), by gender, and category[1]	17	12	15	9	5

[1]Workgroup Chairs are double-counted in the Chair's Workgroup.

Table 1.3.3 Athena Swan Self Assessment Team

Name and Position		Role on SAT
John Morrison (M) Professor		Chair of the CSIT Self-Assessment Team, Member of the Editorial Team
Margaret Hynes (F) Executive Assistant		SAT Administrative support
Klaas-Jan Stol (M) Lecturer, Funded Investigator at Lero Research Centre, Supervisor at ADVANCE-CRT		Workgroup Liaison; data visualisation, SAT document manager. Member of the Chair's Workgroup, Member of the Editorial Team
Julie Walsh (F) Executive Assistant		SAT Administrative support
Workgroup 1: Department and Its Context		
Kieran Herley (M) Lecturer, Chair of the Academic Programmes and Curriculum Development Committee (APCD)		Chair of Workgroup 1: Department and Its Context
Martin Moriarty (M) Systems Administrator		Member of Workgroup 1: Department and Its Context
John O'Mullane (M) Lecturer		Member of Workgroup 1: Department and Its Context

Derbhile Timon (F) School Manager

Member of Workgroup 1: Department and Its Context. Member of the Chair's Workgroup, Member of the Editorial Team

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Workgroup 2: Academic and Research Careers

Dirk Pesch (M) Professor, Director of ADVANCE-CRT, Co-PI with Connect and Confirm Research Centres; Steering Committee Member of SFI Enable Spoke

Chair of Workgroup 2: Academic and Research Careers. Member of the Chair's Workgroup

Vlad Ionescu (M) PhD Candidate

Member of Workgroup 2: Academic and Research Careers

Buvana Ganesh (F) PhD Candidate

Member of Workgroup 2: Academic and Research Careers

Md. Noor-A-Rahim (M) Research Fellow

Member of Workgroup 2: Academic and Research Careers

Jason Quinlan (M) Lecturer

Member of Workgroup 2: Academic and Research Careers

Rosane Minghim (F) Lecturer, Supervisor with ADVANCE-CRT

Member of Workgroup 2: Academic and Research Careers

Begüm Genç (F) Postdoctoral researcher at Insight, now moved to Apple

Member of Workgroup 2: Academic and Research Careers

Barry O'Sullivan (M) Professor, Director of Insight Research Centre, co-PI with Confirm Research Centre		Member of Workgroup 2: Academic and Research Careers
Andrea Visentin (M) Lecturer		Member of Workgroup 2: Academic and Research Careers

Workgroup 3: Professional, Managerial and Support Staff Careers

Aisling O'Driscoll (F) Lecturer, Course Director of BSc Computer Science (BScCS), Funded Investigator at Connect Research Centre, Supervisor at ADVANCE-CRT		Chair Workgroup 3: Professional, Managerial and Support Staff Careers. Member of the Chair's Workgroup
James Duggan (M) Senior Executive Assistant, ADVANCE-CRT		Member of Workgroup 3: Professional, Managerial and Support Staff Careers
David O'Byrne (M) Computing Systems Manager		Member of Workgroup 3: Professional, Managerial and Support Staff Careers
Adrian O'Riordan (M) Lecturer		Member of Workgroup 3: Professional, Managerial and Support Staff Careers
Eleanor O'Riordan (F) Administrator with Insight Research Centre		Member of Workgroup 3: Professional, Managerial and Support Staff Careers
Youngsin O'Sé (F) Senior Executive Assistant		Member of Workgroup 3: Professional, Managerial and Support Staff Careers

Workgroup 4: Inclusion and Belonging		
Paolo Palmieri (M) Lecturer, Funded Investigator at Connect and Insight Research Centres, Supervisor at ADVANCE-CRT and CRT-AI		Chair of Workgroup 4: Inclusion and Belonging. Member of the Chair's Workgroup
Andrea Balogh (F) PhD Candidate		Member of Workgroup 4: Inclusion and Belonging
Laura Maye (F) Lecturer, Course Director BA Psychology & Computing (BAPC), Supervisor with ADVANCE-CRT		Member of Workgroup 4: Inclusion and Belonging
Joanne Murphy (F) Administrative Officer		Member of Workgroup 4: Inclusion and Belonging
Sabin Tabirca (M) Senior Lecturer, Supervisor at ADVANCE-CRT, Coordinator of the Munster Programming Training (MPT)		Member of Workgroup 4: Inclusion and Belonging
Ahmed Zahran (M) Lecturer, Course Director MSc Data Science and Analytics (MScDSA), Funded Investigator Connect Research Centre, Supervisor at ADVANCE-CRT		Member of Workgroup 4: Inclusion and Belonging

Information on how the chair was appointed and on what supports or resources the institution and/or department has given the chair to lead the self-assessment process

Following an open invitation, in March 2021, the HoS appointed Prof. Morrison to SAT Chair. Prof. Morrison has over 30 years experience of successfully leading large national and international research programmes and was recognised in 2017 by Enterprise Ireland as a Champion of EU Research. The Chair was supported by the School Manager and the Workgroup Liaison, who liaised with WG Chairs to analyse and visualise data, and compiled the application document.

Comment on whether the self-assessment team is representative of the department, including if there is adequate representation of senior staff

All of the female academic staff members and over 50% of female PMS staff were members of the SAT. In total 41% of the SAT were female. Six members (21%) of the SAT were senior staff, including 3 Professors, 1 Senior Lecturer, 1 Systems Administration Manager, and 1 School Manager.

b Provide information on the preparation and delivery of this application by the department. This should include:

+ an overview of the approach taken to evidence-gathering and analysis. Details of consultation response rates, disaggregated by gender, should be provided;
+ information on plans for evaluating progress, including action plan implementation, over the coming four-year period. This should make reference to how often the SAT will meet, and how SAT succession and turnover will be planned and managed;
+ information on how the findings and activity of the self-assessment team are, and will continue to be, communicated to senior management and the wider department.

An overview of the approach taken to evidence-gathering and analysis. Details of consultation response rates, disaggregated by gender, should be provided

The SAT held several orientation meetings in April and May of 2021 to understand the scope of the AS process and to share ideas and experiences. Meetings were also held between UCC's EDI unit and the SAT Chair.

At the time the SAT was formed, Covid-19 restrictions were in full force. A Microsoft Teams channel was created for the SAT, and all SAT meetings were conducted online. All staff responded positively to the challenges of working remotely.

The SAT began working with the standard survey provided by the EDI unit; this was augmented to allow for more in-depth feedback. Questions were added on parental leave, on experiences of new staff and on experiences of staff from under-represented groups.

There were 56 responses, giving a participation rate of 69%. The response rates by gender for academic and Professional Management and Support (PMS) staff reflect the gender balance in the school. Tables 1.3.4 and 1.3.5 present the response rates by gender and by role. Those who did not disclose their gender ('prefer not to say') did not identify their role in the school.

Table 1.3.4 Survey response by gender, compared to total School staff count and gender distribution, and response rate by gender

Gender	Gender representation of survey respondents		Gender representation of all staff School of CSIT		Overall Response rate
	Count	%	Count	%	
Female	16	28.6%	19	23.5%	84.2%
Male	37	66.1%	62	76.5%	59.7%
Prefer not to say	3	5.4%	n/a	n/a	n/a
Total	56	100.0%	81	100.0%	69.1%

Table 1.3.5 Survey response by role

Category	Total survey responses		Female survey responses		Male survey responses	
	Count	%	Count	%	Count	%
Professional, Managerial and Support Staff	14	25.0%	8	50.00%	6	16.2%
Research Staff	16	28.6%	7	43.75%	9	24.3%
Academic Staff	21	41.1%	1	6.25%	20	54.1%
Teaching Staff	2	5.4%	0	0.00%	2	5.4%
Total	53[1]	100.0%	16	100.00%	37	100.0%

[1] Three respondents preferred not to state their gender, which explains the discrepancy with Table 1.3.4.

Responses to certain questions were low. Following an invitation to all staff, 12 colleagues participated in three focus group sessions (for academic, PMS, and research staff) that were organised in May-June 2022, covering the following topics:

1. Flexible working;
2. Support for colleagues with caring obligations;
3. Support for career progression and development;
4. School culture.

Furthermore, four one-on-one interviews were undertaken with School Management. Institutional data were provided by Department of Human Resources (HR) and Central

Academic Services. The university's EDI unit mediated all data, ensuring proper procedures and policies were applied.

All WG activity and meeting minutes were stored and shared through the dedicated Microsoft Teams channel. This unrestricted access to data helped to support communications across the entire SAT.

Each WG met weekly. The Chair's Workgroup met fortnightly, briefed each other on the activities of the previous period, coordinated cross-cutting WG activities, and planned actions for the coming period. The entire SAT met monthly and were briefed by the WG Chairs. Feedback from the entire SAT was invited, and was considered by each WG in subsequent meetings. Every effort was made to ensure that the SAT meetings were inclusive and open to diverse opinions. The SAT meetings were timed to precede the monthly school meeting, where an update on SAT activities was a standing item on the agenda. Figure 1.3.1 shows the SAT activity timeline.

Members of the SAT took part in the online AdvanceHE training seminars and colleagues from schools and universities who were successful in achieving AS accreditation gave generously of their time to talk to the SAT and to share their experiences, including Professor Ita Richardson (University of Limerick), and Professor Lucy Hederman (Trinity College Dublin).

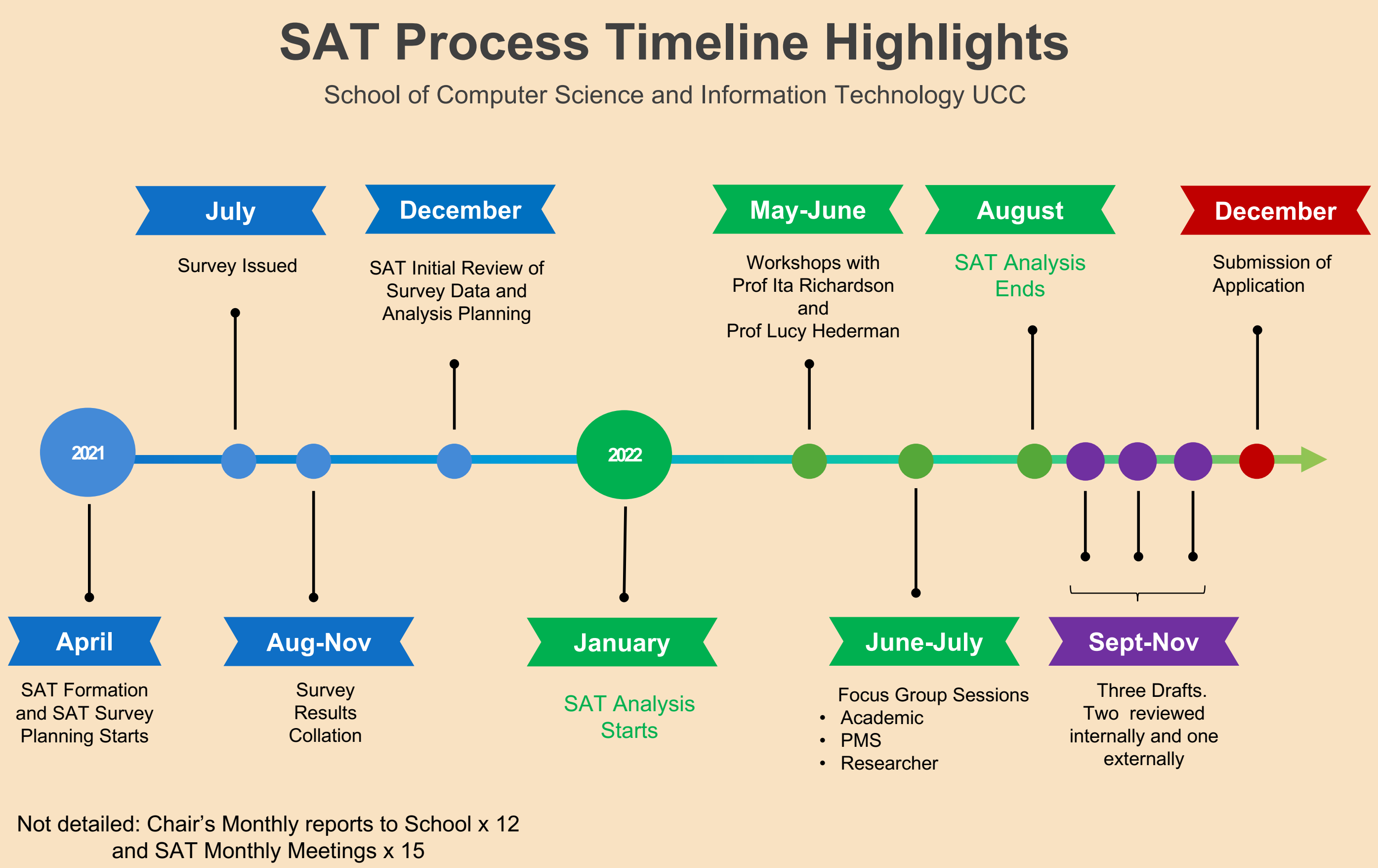
Information on plans for evaluating progress, including action plan implementation, over the coming four-year period. This should make reference to how often the SAT will meet, and how SAT succession and turnover will be planned and managed

In 2023, the school structure will be augmented with the EDIIC, thus replacing the AS SAT. It will be chaired by a senior member of staff and having male and female representation from academic, PMS, and research staff (Action 1.3.1).

> **ACTION 1.3.1: Establish an EDI Implementation Committee**
>
> Establish an EDI Implementation Committee (EDIIC) to progress and monitor the implementation of the AS SAT Action Plan. ☞

Succession planning and turnover of the EDIIC membership will be managed by the HoS, biennially using the same mechanisms for all other administrative appointments. Each member of the EDIIC will be also be a member of one of the School Standing Committees: the Academic Programmes and Curriculum Development (APCD); the Graduate Studies; Outreach; Research; Teaching and Learning; and the Student Experience. There they will act as an EDI champion, highlighting issues of concern.

Figure 1.3.1 Timeline of events



Information on how the findings and activity of the self-assessment team are, and will continue to be, communicated to senior management and the wider department

The EDIIC will be responsible for evaluating progress and for overseeing the implementation of the action plan. The EDIIC will meet monthly, to review progress, measure success and impact and take any actions necessary to progress the action agenda. The EDIIC Chair will report bi-annually to the school (Action 1.3.2). The EDIIC will act as the main conduit between the school and the College's EDI committee.

ACTION 1.3.2: Continuous updates to school

EDIIC Chair to report progress on EDI agenda twice yearly or more often if needed at school meetings. ☞

In addition, to gauge the cultural impact of the AS implementation plan on staff and students, the EDIIC will conduct a review in 2026 (Action 1.3.3).

ACTION 1.3.3: Review AS impact Year 3

Review the impact of AS Implementation Plan in Year 3. ☞

2

An assessment of the department's gender equality context and wider equality context

In Section 2, applicants should evidence how they meet Criterion B:

- Evidence-based recognition of the issues and opportunities facing the applicant

Recommended word count: 8,000 words

1 Overview of the department and its context

a Provide a description of the department's structures to advance equality. This should include:

- teaching and research focus, including discipline coverage and any areas of specialism;
- the total number of staff by gender and category of post;
- the total number of students by programme type and gender;
- information on location/s.

Teaching and research focus, including discipline coverage and any areas of specialism

Table 2.1.1 presents an overview of the school's main teaching activities. The school has strategically diversified its portfolio in the last decade by introducing a suite of interdisciplinary programmes (denoted ⋆) in Data Science (BScDSA and MScDSA), Digital Humanities (BADHIT) and Psychology and Computing (BAPC), designed to increase student numbers overall and particularly to improve gender balance.

Table 2.1.1 Overview of the programmes on offer at CSIT

Title	Acronym	First Intake	Description	Intake (2022)
BSc in Computer Science	BScCS	1979	Mainstream undergraduate CS degree	85
BA in Digital Humanities and IT⋆	BADHIT	2014	Blends IT, digital humanities and traditional arts and humanities subjects	50
BSc in Data Science and Analytics⋆	BScDSA	2018	Combines statistics and computing; focussed on data science	30
BA in Psychology and Computing⋆	BAPC	2018	Degree combining psychology and computing with an emphasis on human aspects of computing	30
Higher Diploma in Computer Science	HDACT	1981	Conversion programme for graduates of any discipline	40
MSc in Computing Science	MScCS	1995	Advanced degree for CS graduates	30
MSc in Interactive Media	MScIM	1999	Conversion programme for graduates of any discipline; emphasis on IT for digital media	40
MSc in Data Science and Analytics⋆	MScDSA	2013	Combines statistics and computing; focussed on data science	30

Research in the school falls into four thematic areas:

1. Artificial Intelligence, Data Analytics and Algorithmics
2. Networks, Computer Architectures and Software Systems
3. Interactive Media and Human Computer Interaction
4. Security, Privacy and Ethics

The bulk of this activity is concentrated in research groups and centres such as Insight and Connect (Table 2.1.2) and two centres for research training (CRTs, see Table 2.1.3) hosted within the school.

Table 2.1.2 Funded research centres within or affiliated with the school

Name	Focus	Website
Insight	Data science, analytics, and artificial intelligence, including decision optimisation	https://www.insight-centre.ie
Connect	Future networks and communications	https://connectcentre.ie/
Enable	Smart environments	https://www.enable-research.ie/
Confirm	Smart manufacturing	https://confirm.ie/
Lero	Software research, including complex systems	https://www.lero.ie
MISL	Networks and systems, with a focus on mobile/wireless and multimedia	https://www.ucc.ie/en/misl/

Table 2.1.3 Centres for research training (CRTs) in the school

Name	Focus	Website
CRT-AI	SFI programme to provide research training in Artifical Intelligence; Provides funding for 120 PhD students over four years between 2019-2023 across five partner institutions.	https://www.crt-ai.ie/
Advance-CRT	SFI programme to provide research training on future networks and the Internet of Things with applications for sustainable and independent living; Provides funding for 120 PhD students over four years between 2019-2023 across five partner institutions.	https://www.advance-crt.ie/

The total number of staff by gender and category of post

Table 2.1.4 provides a snapshot of staff numbers in the school. Professional, Managerial, and Support Staff (PMS) includes those in administrative roles and in IT support roles. Researchers includes only those who conduct research; those in research support roles are classified as PMS, as their work and concerns align more closely with other PMS staff. Some have permanent PMS posts in UCC, but are acting in more senior roles within research centres.

Females are under-represented in almost all categories, particularly in research and academic roles. The school is acutely aware of this imbalance and it is a strategic priority to address this over time. This issue and some actions to address it are explored in Section 2.

Table 2.1.4 Headcount summary of CSIT (2020)

Category	Role	M	F	F%	Total
Staff	Academics	30	3	9%	33
	Professional, Managerial, and Support (PMS) Staff[1]	13	12	48%	25
	Researchers	19	4	17%	23
	Subtotal staff	62	19	23%	81
Students	Undergraduates	390	121	24%	511
	Postgraduates (taught)	70	59	46%	129
	Postgraduates (research)	39	6	13%	45
	Subtotal students	499	186	27%	685

[1]PMS numbers include IT and research support staff.

The total number of students by programme type and gender

Table 2.1.5 summarises student numbers by gender. Computer Science (CS) programmes internationally have struggled with under-representation of females. Gender balance tends to be better for interdisciplinary computing programmes.

Information on location(s)

Figure 2.1.1 shows the Western Gateway Building (WGB) on campus, the base for all CSIT staff and most activities. Before the school was relocated to the WGB in 2009, the school was dispersed across a number of locations. The single location provides far more opportunities for interaction.

b Analyse three years of data on undergraduate students by

- gender and degree programme, with reference to discipline-specific benchmark data;
- gender and degree attainment;
- gender and foundation courses.

Table 2.1.5 Number of students by programme and gender (2020)

	Programme	Student count	% F
Undergraduate programmes	BSc in Computer Science	299	14%
	BA in Digital Humanities and IT ⋆	120	44%
	BSc in Data Science and Analytics ⋆	51	20%
	BA in Psychology and Computing ⋆	41	39%
	Subtotal undergraduate students	511	24%
Postgraduate taught programmes	Higher Diploma in Applied Computing	22	41%
	MSc in Interactive Media	38	68%
	MSc in Computing Science	30	33%
	MSc in Data Science and Analytics ⋆	39	36%
	Subtotal Postgraduate taught students	129	46%
Postgraduate research	Postgraduate research students	45	13%
Total student count		685	27%

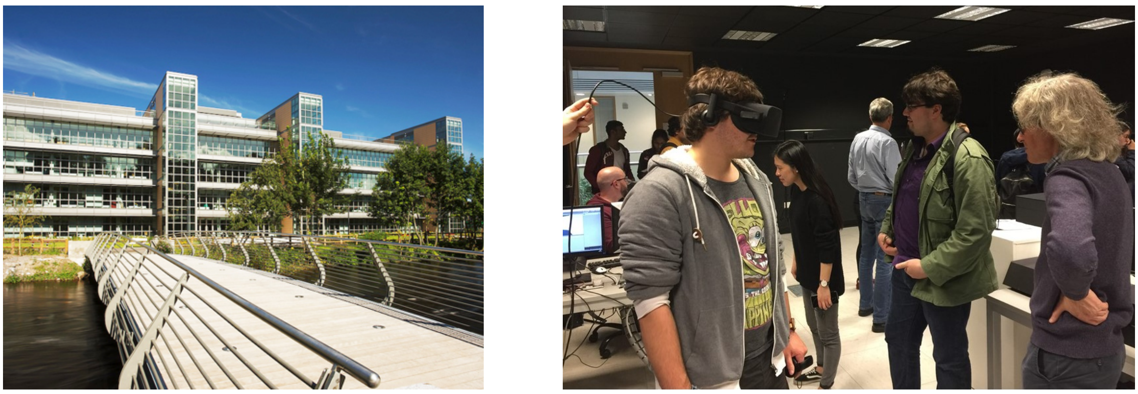
Rows marked with ⋆ indicate joint programmes with other schools.

Gender and degree programme, with reference to discipline-specific benchmark data

Figure 2.1.2 summarises three years' enrolment statistics by gender for our undergraduate programmes.[1] The figure shows a wide variation in female enrolment rates from

[1] BScDSA and BAPC started in 2018-19.

Figure 2.1.1 Western Gateway Building: home to CSIT.



14-16% in the BScCS to 44-50% in BADHIT. The former aligns better with the school's existing research strengths, so any increase in female undergraduate numbers there may provide a bigger pool of potential research postgraduates in time.

Figure 2.1.2 Enrolment of undergraduate students 2017-2020

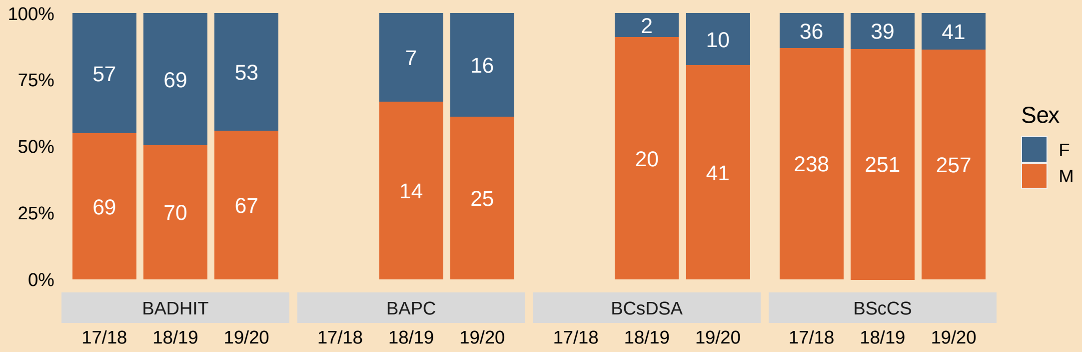


Figure 2.1.3 shows the evolution of the gender breakdown linked to the introduction of new programmes (BScDSA, BADHIT, BAPC). BADHIT and BAPC have improved the overall gender balance. In 2009-10, prior to the introduction of these newer programmes, the percentage of females was 14%, compared with 24-25% for the period shown.

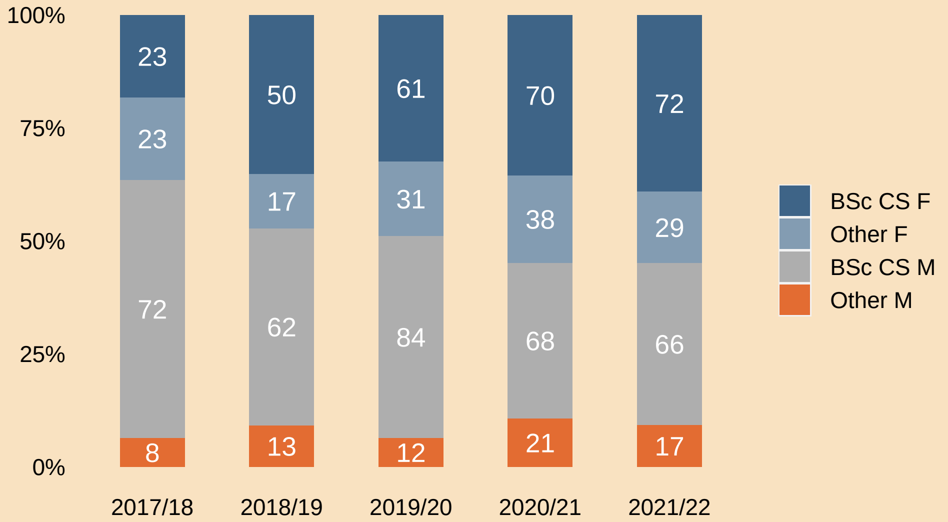
Table 2.1.6 compares CSIT's gender participation rates for undergraduate programmes with Irish (HEA) and UK (HESA) benchmarks. CSIT's 22-24% is somewhat better than the Irish (HEA) figure of 19-20% and 15-16% for the UK (HESA).

Table 2.1.6 Percentage of females on undergraduate programmes for full-time students, benchmarked nationally (HEA) and with the UK (HESA)

Year	UCC CSIT	HEA[1]	HESA[2]
2017-18	22%	19%	15%
2018-19	25%	19%	15%
2019-20	24%	20%	16%

[1]Higher Education Authority (Ireland) percentages reflect programmes classified as Information and Communication Technologies (International Standard Classification of Education);
[2]Higher Education Statistics Agency (UK) (HESA) reflect programmes under heading of Computing.

Figure 2.1.3 Evolution of male/female intake for the BScCS programme vs. other undergraduate programmes within CSIT



Undergraduate gender and degree attainment

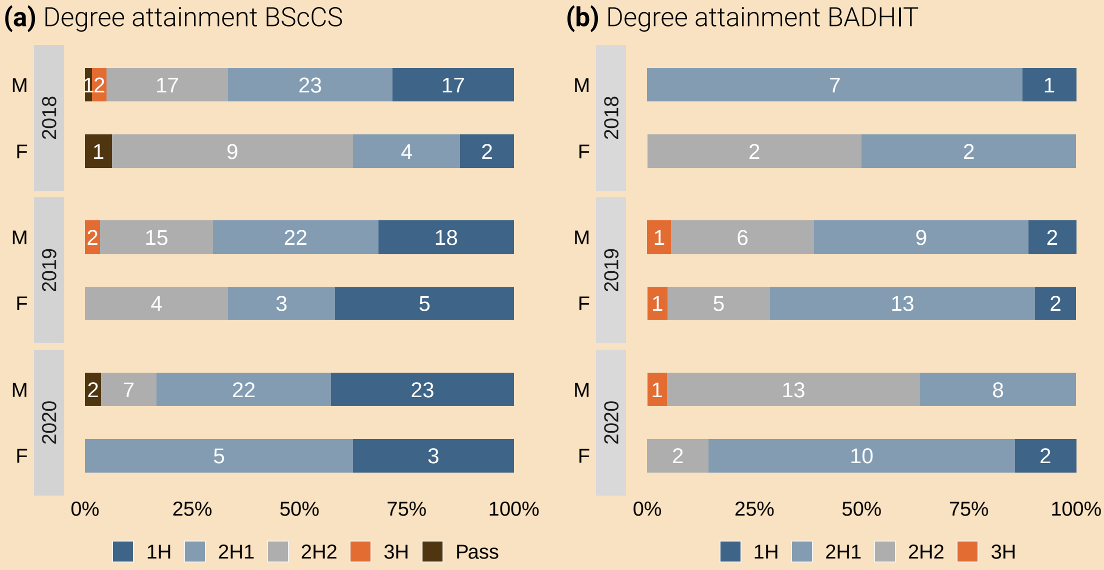
Figure 2.1.4 summarises the degree classifications received by BScCS and BADHIT graduates for the years 2018-2020. (The first graduates for the other two undergraduate programmes emerged only in 2021-22.)

Females are well represented among those receiving higher degree classifications (Figure 2.1.6). The proportion of BADHIT female students receiving higher grades (2H1, 1H) was higher than their male classmates for two of the three years shown. The Psychology & Computing (BAPC) and Data Science & Analytics (BScDSA) programmes only started in 2018; Figure 2.1.5 compares most recent degree attainment data across all four UG programmes.

Undergraduate gender and foundation courses

CSIT does not offer foundation courses.

Figure 2.1.4 Degree attainment BScCS and BADHIT



c Analyse three years of data on postgraduate taught students by:

- gender and degree programme, with reference to discipline-specific benchmark data;
- gender and degree attainment.

Postgraduate taught student gender and degree programme, with reference to discipline-specific benchmark data

Figure 2.1.7 shows three years' enrolment data for our taught postgraduate programmes. Female participation rates are generally better for postgraduate programmes than for undergraduate. The MScIM, which also attracts students with non-computing backgrounds, is the only programme where females (56-68%) outnumber males. Both MScCS and MScDSA have a high proportion of non-EU students and a significantly better gender balance, possibly due to higher participation among females in STEM subjects in some non-EU countries.

Figure 2.1.7 shows increased female enrolments in our postgraduate taught programme from 37% to 43%. Table 2.1.7 shows CSIT to be higher (37-45%) compared with national (HEA) figures and UK (HESA) figures of 29-32% and 30-31%, respectively.

Figure 2.1.5 Degree attainment undergraduate students across all 4 undergraduate programmes (2022)

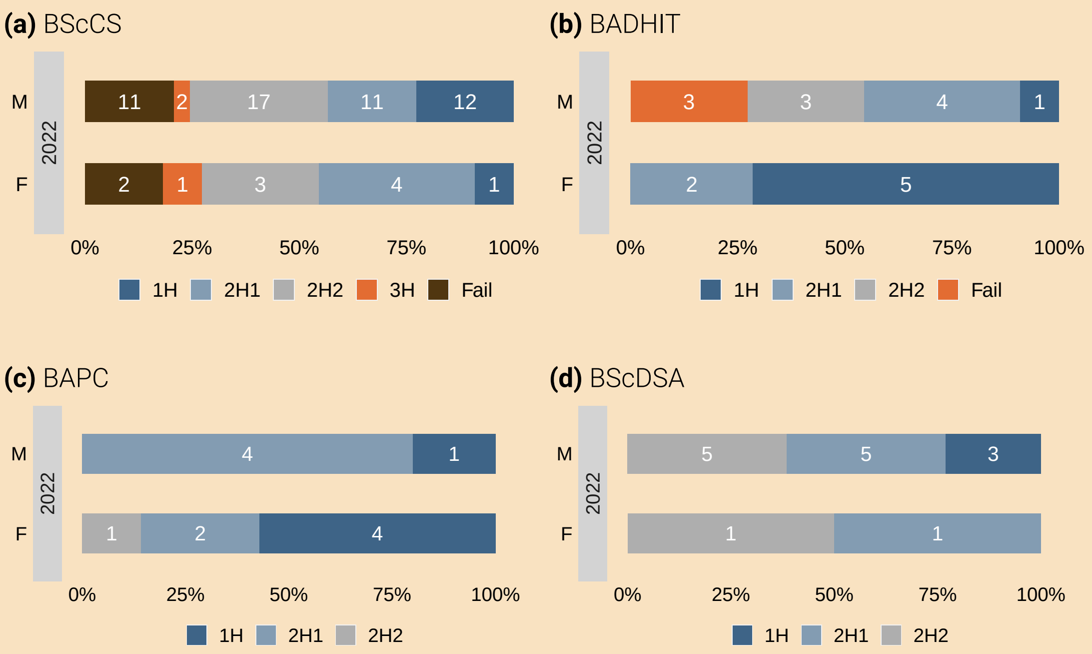


Figure 2.1.6 Two CSIT undergraduate students receiving SEFS College Graduate of the Year (and runner-up) Awards.

Postgraduate taught student gender and degree attainment

Figure 2.1.8 plots three year's data on the degree classifications achieved for Postgraduate Taught (PGT) programmes; females feature prominently among those achieving higher grades.

Figure 2.1.7 Enrolment postgraduate students 2017-2020

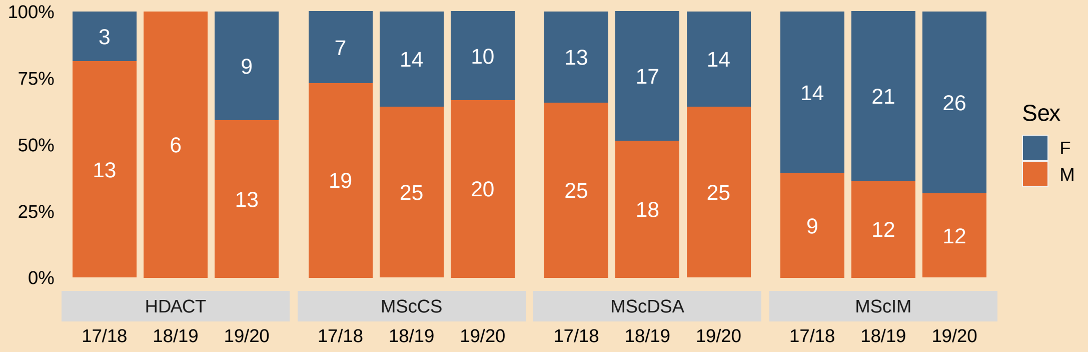


Table 2.1.7 Percentage of females on postgraduate taught programmes, benchmarked nationally (HEA) and with the UK (HESA) (full-time students only)

Year	UCC CSIT	HEA	HESA
2017-18	37%	29%	30%
2018-19	45%	32%	31%
2019-20	43%	32%	30%

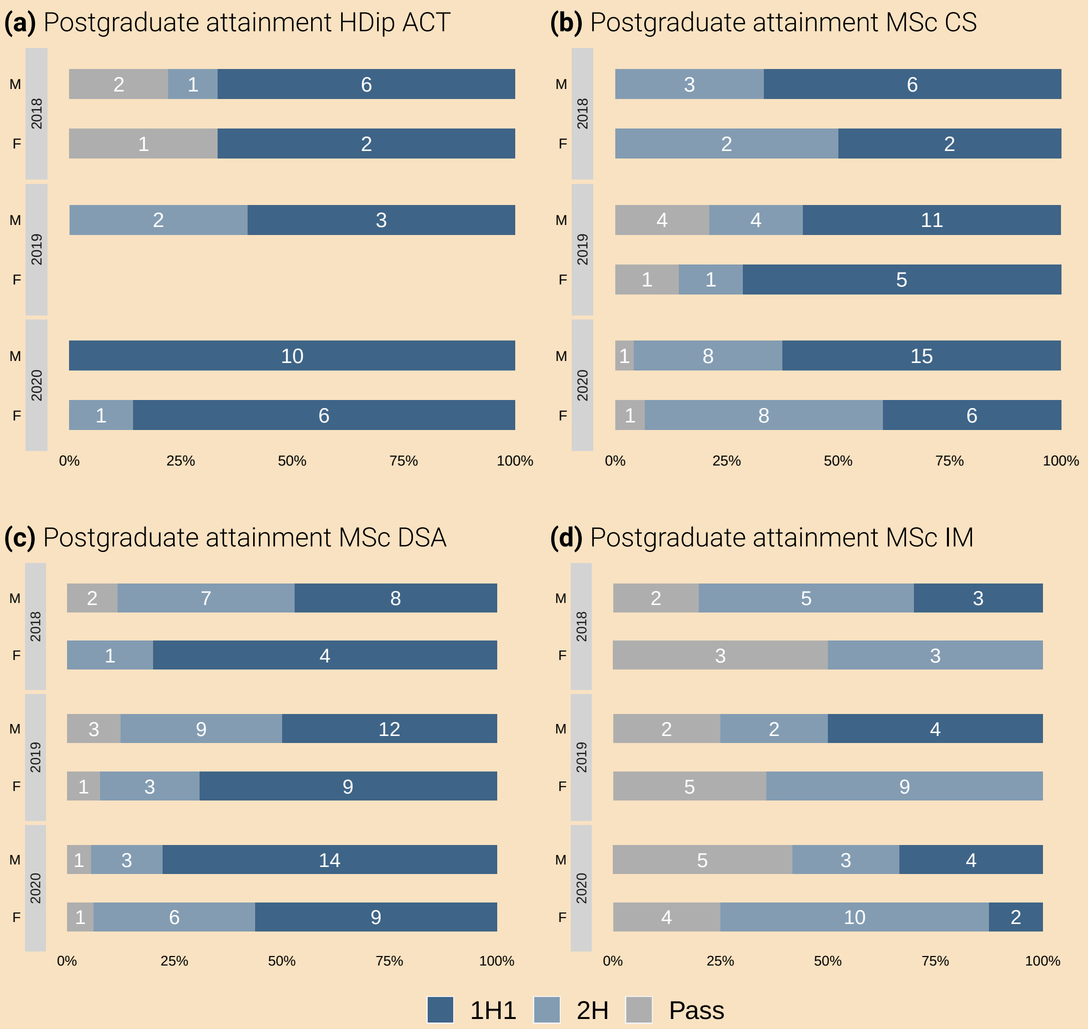
d Analyse three years of data on postgraduate research students by:

+ gender and enrolment;
+ gender and application, offer, and enrolment, with comment on how this data is collected and evaluated by the department, and on any gender disparities in student funding;
+ gender and completion rates.

Postgraduate research student gender and enrolment

Table 2.1.8 shows three years' data on postgraduate research students (virtually all PhDs). The dip in 2019-20 reflects the absence of funding before the start of the CRTs. CRTs have explicit targets to increase female students (40%) (Table 2.1.9). The percentage of females among Postgraduate Research (PGR) students is significantly above that of the undergraduate population. As SFI has gender targets attached to

Figure 2.1.8 Degree attainment postgraduate students



other funding, a similar pattern is expected among the non-CRT PGR intake in future years.

A snapshot of PhD intake by research centre or CRT for 2022-23 is shown in Table 2.1.10, indicating that gender balance is improving. Figure 2.1.9 shows the 2019 cohort of ADVANCE-CRT.

Table 2.1.8 Number of postgraduate students registered from 2017-18 to 2019-20 by gender

Year	M	F	Total	%F
2017-18	30	11	41	27%
2018-19	26	19	45	42%
2019-20	39	6	45	13%

Table 2.1.9 Postgraduate student intake since 2019-20

Year	M	F	Total	%F
2019-20	15	4	19	21%
2020-21	13	9	22	41%
2021-22	5	6	11	55%

Table 2.1.10 Postgraduate research students registered 2022-23 by centre and gender

Research Centre	M	F	Total	%F
Advance-CRT	12	8	20	40%
CRT-AI	8	4	12	33%
Insight	11	5	14	36%
Other[1]	11	4	15	27%
Total	42	21	63	33%

[1]Other includes students attached to research centres such as MISL, Confirm, Lero and Enable.

Postgraduate research student gender and application, offer, and enrolment, with comment on how this data is collected and evaluated by the department, and on any gender disparities in student funding

Historically, the PGR application process was handled by individual centres or PIs who maintain local records (see below). There has been no school-level monitoring of number of applicants, offers and acceptances by gender. PGR application data will be collated under Action 2.1.1.

Figure 2.1.9 ADVANCE-CRT cohort 2019

ACTION 2.1.1: Collate postgraduate research application aata

Put procedures in place to gather and maintain gender specific data on the number of applicants, shortlisted, and appointments in respect to funded PhD positions. ☞

Table 2.1.11 summarises the number of applications and enrolments by gender for the two CRTs since their introduction in 2019. The strategy of a quota of 40% female enrolments has by and large been achieved in the CRTs.

Postgraduate research student gender and completion rates

Table 2.1.12 shows data on PhD completions (30% female); data were derived from registration and graduation data. These figures may overstate completion times due to the lag between "finishing up" (*viva voce*, submission) and graduation.

Table 2.1.11 CRT data on applications and enrolments by gender

		National						UCC		
		Applications			Enrolments			Enrolments		
Centre	Year	M	F	F%	M	F	F%	M	F	F%
CRT-AI	2019	145	89	38%	17	14	45%	3	1	25%
	2020	245	110	31%	15	16	50%	3	1	25%
	2021	175	65	27%	14	9	39%	2	2	50%
ADVANCE-CRT	2019	162	54	25%	15	7	32%	3	2	40%
	2020	390	139	26%	9	10	53%	6	4	40%
	2021	291	135	31%	16	13	45%	2	2	50%

The application process for CRTs is handled at consortium level and students are matched with specific institutions and supervisors. Hence, it is not possible to disaggregate applications by institution.

Table 2.1.12 Number of PhD graduations and average completion times by gender for 2017-18 to 2019-20

	Male		Female	
Academic Year	Count	Average completion time in months	Count	Average completion time in months
2017-18	2	60	1	-
2018-19	5	64	2	61
2019-20	7	62	3	64
Total	14	62	6	63

Completions times include full-time students only.

Table 2.1.13 shows the completion rates (27% female) for those expected to finish during the three-year reference period 2017-18 to 2019-20, assuming fours years to complete.

The average completion time was similar for both genders (60¼ (M), 63¼ (F) months) and significantly above the 48 month target. UCC's recently introduced policy on annual progress reviews for research students provides a framework for managing these issues.

Table 2.1.13 PhD completion rates by gender for those starting 2013-14 to 2015-16

	2013-14		2014-15		2015-16		Total	
	M	F	M	F	M	F	M	F
Number new registrations	6	3	8	2	10	3	24	8
Number who completed	5	2	4	2	7	2	16	6
Average completion time (months)	63	71	59	59	59	60	60	63
Number yet to complete	1	0	1	0	1	0	3	0

Figure 2.1.10 Left: graduation day. Right: PhD Review Day

e Comment and reflect on the relationship (if any) between the department's outreach, engagement, and support activities and issues or opportunities in the student pipeline. This should include comment on how the department recognises staff and student contributions to these activities and monitors the gender balance of those involved.

The school participates in all university outreach activities including Open Days and careers guidance briefings (Figure 2.1.11). It also hosts its own initiatives, including annual information evenings, a very popular programme of weekend programming classes[2] and summer camps,[3] aimed at second-level students, in addition to regular school visits (Table 2.1.14). All activities are tailored to support diversity of undergraduate intake.

Our existing outreach, marketing and support measures have evolved in an ad-hoc manner over the years; the current AS exercise has highlighted the need for a compre-

[2] Munster Programming Training (MPT) https://www.ucc.ie/en/csschools/mpt/

[3] https://www.ucc.ie/en/csschools/ictsummercamp/

Figure 2.1.11 From left to right: Outreach activities at CSIT. Head of School Prof Utz Roedig with potential future students. Visit from transition year students. Munster Programming Training. UCC Open Day.

hensive audit of these activities to assess their effectiveness and reflect on how they might be reconfigured to address the two key challenges in the student pipeline:

Table 2.1.14 School visits to female-only, male-only, and mixed-gender schools

Academic Year	Male-only schools	Female-only schools	Mixed-gender schools	Total
2018-19	4	1	3	8
2019-20	1	2	2	5
2020-21 (virtual)	5	5	10	20
2021-22	3	0	2	5
Total	13	8	17	38

School visits during 2020/21 were virtual due to Covid-19; school visits did not resume in full during 2021/22.

1. the under-representation of females in the BScCS and BScDSA (Table 2.1.5);
2. the lack of female undergraduates who opt to progress to graduate research studies.

A survey of current female undergraduates (Action 2.1.2) will help inform a review of existing marketing and outreach activities and reconfigure these activities to improve recruitment of females and to enhance diversity of intake more generally (Actions 2.1.3 and 2.1.4). Action 2.1.2 will also diagnose issues with how the school projects itself to prospective undergraduates.

ACTION 2.1.2: Investigate female perceptions towards Computer Science and careers

Survey existing UG females to assess what influenced their decision to study CS (first years), their experience with their programme (middle years) and to gauge attitudes and perceptions towards research/academic careers (final years). ☞

ACTION 2.1.3: Improve focus on diversity in outreach activities

Revise school outreach programme to increase the number of visits to second-level schools with students from diverse backgrounds. ☞

ACTION 2.1.4: Re-assess and re-configure existing outreach and support measures

Review existing marketing materials and outreach activities to assess their effectiveness to attract female school leavers to choose computer science. ☞

Linking with Action 5.1.1 of UCC's AS Action Plan 2019-2023,[4] Actions 2.1.5 and 2.1.6 will underpin an overhaul of materials to help reshape recruitment materials for future academic, research and PMS vacancies (e.g. Action 2.2.2 and Action 2.3.1).

UCC INSTITUTIONAL ATHENA SWAN BRONZE AWARD ACTION 5.1.1

Revise equality of opportunity statement in recruitment material to reflect a more inclusive, positive and specific commitment to equality principles Develop guidance for writing equality-focused post advertisements, including statements encouraging applications from the underrepresented groups.

[4] https://www.ucc.ie/en/media/support/edi/athenaswan/AthenaSWANUCCActionPlan2019-2023.pdf

ACTION 2.1.5: Develop gender proofing guidelines for materials

Develop guidelines to inform the future production of gender-proof advertisements, materials, and visuals that are gender positive, inclusive, and welcoming of diversity. ☞

ACTION 2.1.6: Boost visibility of females

Boost visibility of female researchers, alumnae and professionals and highlight their work to provide role models for female UGs and prospective students. ☞

The recent appointment of a dedicated mentor has proved effective in improving student experience for international students. A mentor for female undergraduate students will be appointed to offer guidance and support (Action 2.1.7), help coordinate various female-focused initiatives, and encourage female undergraduates to pursue career-enhancing opportunities e.g., IGNITE entrepreneur incubation initiative,[5] scholarships and internships aimed at female undergraduates (e.g. Huawei, Google), participation in events, such as the Irish Programming Olympiad and the International Olympiad for Informatics and engagement with organisations devoted to supporting young women in STEM such as iWish,[6] WiSTEM[7] and IEEE Women in Engineering (Figure 2.1.12).

ACTION 2.1.7: Appoint mentor for female undergraduates

Appoint a mentor for female UG students to provide guidance and encouragement and to support their academic and career development. ☞

Encouraging female undergraduates to consider a research career will be challenging given economic and career factors explored in Subsection f, however, research internship opportunities may help nurture interest (Action 2.1.8).

ACTION 2.1.8: Internship opportunities for female undergraduates

Provide female undergraduates with internship opportunities in the school's research centers. ☞

The school aims for gender balanced representation (both staff and students) at all outreach activities.

[5] https://www.ucc.ie/en/ignite/
[6] https://www.iwish.ie
[7] https://www.facebook.com/UCCWiSTEM/

Figure 2.1.12 From top left to bottom right: Irish Programming Olympiad; Huawei Scholarships; Google sponsorship of Irish Collegiate Programming Competition; UCC Quercus Talented Students Programme

f Provide data for academic and research staff by gender and grade. Analyse and benchmark the career pipeline.

Table 2.1.15 demonstrates that the gender imbalance is stark for both academic and researchers and at senior levels: there is no female at Senior Postdoctoral level or above nor at Senior Lecturer (SL) level or above.

Table 2.1.16 compares CSIT’s academic staff profile with that of two peer institutions, University College Dublin (UCD) and Trinity College Dublin (TCD). The percentage of female academics at CSIT is 9%, compared with 16% at UCD and 29% at TCD. CSIT has no females at SL level or above, compared with six out of 58 at UCD and five out of 59 at TCD. Higher Education Statistics Agency (UK) (HESA) data (2019-20 ICTS) from the UK indicates 16% professors in CS are females, and 22% of all research and academic staff excluding professors.

CSIT’s academic gender profile is largely a reflection of an uneven recruitment pattern

Table 2.1.15 CSIT academics and researchers (2020)

	Permanent/CID			Fixed-Term			
Grade	M	F	%F	M	F	%F	Total
Academics							
Professor	4	-	-	-	-	-	4
Professor (Scale 2)	4	-	-	-	-	-	4
Senior Lecturer	5	-	-	-	-	-	5
Lecturer (above bar)	14	1	6.7%	1	-	-	16
Lecturer (below bar)	-	1	100%	2	1	33%	4
Subtotal academics	27	2	6.9%	3	1	25%	33
Research staff[1]							
Senior Research Fellow	-	-	-	1	-	-	1
Research Fellow	-	-	-	3	-	-	3
Senior Postdoc	-	-	-	4	-	-	4
Postdoc	-	-	-	10	3	23%	13
Research Assistant	-	-	-	1	1	50%	2
Subtotal researchers	-	-	-	19	4	17.4%	23

[1]Research staff are hired on fixed-term contracts only.

over decades. An expansion of staff numbers in the 1990s and early 2000s was followed by a prolonged hiring drought, which locked in a historical all-male imbalance. Prior to 2017, when our first female colleague was recruited, no permanent academic appointment had been made since 2004.

Table 2.1.16 Academic staff by grade and gender benchmarked against peer institutions

	UCC		UCD		TCD	
Grade	M	F	M	F	M	F
Professors	8	-	7	3	10	3
Senior Lecturer	5	-	17	3	9	2
Lecturer	17	3	25	3	23	12
Subtotal Senior Lecturer or above	13	-	24	6	19	5
Total	30	3	49	9	42	17

Sources: UCD, School of Computer Science (`www.ucd.ie/cs`). TCD, School of Computer Science and Statistics, (`www.scss.tcd.ie`); numbers include some statisticians.

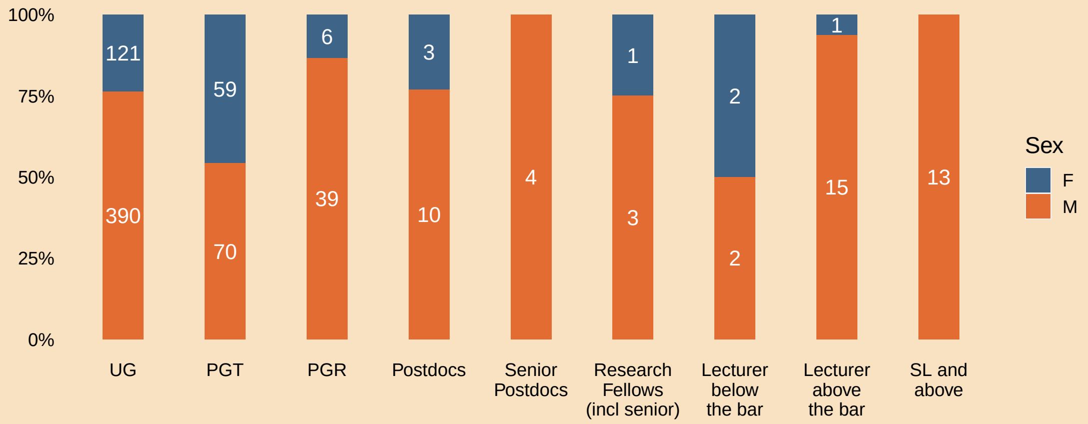
However, since 2017 CSIT has filled 13 academic posts (nine male and four female), two of whom (one male, one female) have since resigned to take up posts in their home country. While this is a step in the right direction, the school realises that much work remains to be done to achieve a healthy gender balance, and will adopt gender-positive recruitment measures described in Section 2 (e.g. Actions 2.2.2–2.2.5).

In the years up to 2027, 12 staff (nine academic, three administrators) are expected to reach the normal retirement age. Some additional new posts are also expected based on increasing student numbers. This significant number of openings presents an opportunity to approach recruitment in a strategic manner, not least to further improve gender balance.

Figure 2.1.13 depicts the career pipeline, showing the the percentage of females at different career levels from undergraduates to professors. The "pipeline" metaphor can result in an over-focus on flow from beginning to end, potentially downplaying important inward flows at various stages. For example, very few Irish undergraduates progress to masters programmes and fewer still to research studies. The healthy numbers and gender balance in our postgraduate programmes is largely due to non-EU students. These inward flows are very welcome but camouflage the dearth of female undergraduates progressing through PhD and onward to research and academic careers.

The tapering proportion of females from undergraduates to lecturers to senior academics is a global phenomenon in CS, but the complete lack of females in senior grades

Figure 2.1.13 Career pipeline: gender distribution across academic levels of seniority, from undergraduate students to Senior Lecturer (SL) and above (2020)



at UCC is an outlier even within our traditionally male-dominated discipline. The greatest choke points appear to be:

1. From undergraduate to research postgraduate
2. From research roles to academic posts
3. From Lecturer to SL and beyond

Employment prospects for Irish computing graduates are buoyant and, unlike other STEM disciplines, further postgraduate study is not required for career opportunities in industry.

Factors deterring research students and postdocs from pursuing academic careers are explored further in Section 2. Poor PhD stipends (currently at €18,500 p.a.) and low pay for postdoctoral positions relative to attractive industry salaries is one factor. Starting salaries on offer to talented graduates can be a multiple of the PhD stipend. Uncertainties surrounding securing academic positions and promotional opportunities thereafter is another.

As noted, CSIT has no female academics at SL rank or above, so the Lecturer/SL boundary represents a significant choke point. At UCC academics can attain a senior grade either through promotion or direct appointment to an advertised position. Promotion criteria and processes at UCC are dictated entirely by the university and the school has had very limited success with promotions over the years. In the past twenty years, there have been six academic promotions in all (none since 2014; no females as CSIT did not have any female academics until 2017), but only three from Lecturer to SL (most recently in 2008). In the most recent round (2018-2019), only two Lecturers applied for promotion to SL; neither was successful (Table 2.2.4). If promotions are to contribute to improving gender balance at senior levels, the school will proactively support colleagues, particularly females, in navigating UCC's promotion scheme successfully (Action 2.2.6).

Section 2 explores staff experiences and perception with recruitment and promotions and proposes some actions to help improve the gender balance over time.

g Provide data for professional, managerial and support staff by gender and grade. Analyse representation, benchmarking where possible.

Table 2.1.17 gives an overview of the numbers of PMS staff. UCC classifies staff in Computer Science Systems Support (CSSS) as "administrative" rather than "technical."

Table 2.1.17 Professional, Managerial, and Support staff (2020) (includes core and research IT support staff)

		Permanent/CID			Fixed-Term			
		M	F	%F	M	F	%F	Total
Office	Grades 5+ (Admin)	-	2	100%	-	-	-	2
	Senior Executive Assistant	1	1	50%	-	-	-	2
	Executive Assistant	-	2	100%	-	-	-	2
Computer Science Systems Support	Grades 5+ (IT)	5	-	-	-	-	-	5
Research	Support staff	-	-	-	7	7	50%	14
Total		6	5	46%	7	7	50%	25

Among those in administrative roles in the school's office, females predominate; mirroring the situation within the university. The school's core IT staff are exclusively male. This gender pattern for administrative and IT roles is replicated among the research support staff. Section 3 explores this issue in greater depth and presents actions to move the school on a more gender-balanced trajectory for PMS staff (e.g. Action 2.3.1).

By way of comparison, TCD's webpage currently lists 24 administrative staff (21 female, 3 male), nine IT support staff (three female, six male) and six staff classified as technicians (all male).

h Provide data on staff on fixed-term contracts, contracts of indefinite duration/permanent contracts, and hourly-paid contracts by gender and staff category. Outline instances where fixed-term and hourly-paid contract types are used. This should include comment on:

- whether or not numbers of fixed-term/hourly-paid contracts are representative of a typical year;
- the rationale for the use of short-term contracts;
- the extent to which hourly-paid staff contribute to the teaching of core modules and/or services.

Table 2.1.18 summarises CSIT staff by category, contract type and gender for 2020.

Table 2.1.18 CSIT staff by category, contract type and gender (2020)

	Permanent/CID			Fixed-Term			Hourly-Paid			
Category	M	F	%F	M	F	%F	M	F	%F	Total
Academic	27	2	7%	2	2	50%	1	-	0%	34[1]
Researchers	-	-	-	19	4	17%	-	-	-	23
PMS	6	5	45%	7	7	50%	-	-	-	25
Total	33	7	17.5%	28	13	32%	1	-	0%	82

[1]Hourly-paid academic staff were not included in earlier tables. Some fixed-term PMS staff listed here have permanent/CID posts but are operating at a higher grade in research support roles.

Comment on whether or not numbers of fixed-term/hourly-paid contracts are representative of a typical year

The pattern seen in Table 2.1.18 is typical of recent years. Hourly-paid contracts are never used for research or PMS roles and only rarely for academics, as noted below.

Comment on the rationale for the use of short-term contracts

Short-term academic contracts (typically one year) are used to cover temporary vacancies in permanent posts arising from maternity cover and retirements. Also posts tied to new programmes are often sanctioned on a fixed-term basis initially. Three of the fixed-term academic shown in Table 2.1.18 have subsequently received permanent positions, two of whom are female.

Research activity is wholly dependent on the flow of research funding which is inherently impermanent and so all researchers are on fixed-term contracts. A number of those in research administration or research IT support roles have core permanent/Contract of Indefinite Duration (CID) positions, some appointed to a higher-grade from research funds.

Comment on the extent to which hourly-paid staff contribute to the teaching of core modules and/or services

Hourly paid staff are mainly students employed on a part-time basis as laboratory demonstrators or tutors for undergraduate modules. The amount of such work varies by year; in 2019-20, for example, we had 65 hourly paid staff: 54 male and 11 female (17%), which is below the percentage of female undergraduate and taught postgraduates.

A handful of modules (3%) are covered by hourly-paid part-time lecturers—generally postdocs seeking teaching experience.

2 Embedding policy, practice and supports to advance academic and research careers

a Reflecting on recruitment practices in the department

Recruitment to academic and research posts in the department adheres to institutional policy on recruitment, which includes gender-balanced panels and training for assessors	Yes	No
	☐	☒

If you answered 'no', please comment.

The policies that apply to gender-balanced panels and training for selection committee members for academic posts, do not apply to recruiting researchers. Table 2.2.1 shows that in the previous 3 years only 19%, on average, of recruitment committee members for research positions were female, many were entirely male. To address the training requirements and gender-balanced panels, the school will require all committee members to undergo training, e.g., recruitment and selection training (Action 2.2.1).

Table 2.2.1 Selection committee gender balance research

Gender	%
Male	78%
Female	19%
Unknown	3%

ACTION 2.2.1: School policy on research recruitment

Create a school policy on research recruitment. ☞

Table 2.2.2 shows that recruitment for academic posts; over 70% of the selection committees had more than 40% female representation.

Table 2.2.2 Gender equality and selection committees for academic positions

Year	Competition	Selection Committee F	M	%F
2017/18	Professor of Computer Science	3	5	38%
	Lecturer in Computer Science	3	3	50%
	Lecturer in Computer Science	3	3	50%
2018/19	Lecturer in Computer Science (x2)	2	4	33%
	Lecturer in Computer Science (BA Psychology)	3	2	60%
	Lecturer in Computer Science (BA Digital Humanities)	3	2	60%
	Lecturer in Computer Science	2	3	40%
Total		19	22	46%

Note: No recruitment in 2019/2020.

b Provide three years of data on application, shortlist, and appointment rates for recruitment by gender and grade. Where data suggests opportunity for improvement, comment and reflect. Include any other relevant information relating to recruitment processes and practice for academic and research posts in the department.

Academic recruitment is centrally managed by HR. There were nine academic appointments from 2017 to 2019 (Table 2.2.3).

There were significantly fewer female applicants, particularly for the Professorship in 2017/18. No female applicant was appointed in 2017/18, however, in 2018/19, 3 of the 5 appointees were female.

The school is committed to addressing the gender imbalance across academic staff (Table 2.1.15), in particular at SL level and above. It took part in the Strategic Academic Leadership Initiative (SALI) Chair initiative in 2019 and in 2020 for establishing a female professorship for the school. Unfortunately, the school's bid was unsuccessful. In 2021, the school advertised a Professorship in Human Centred Computing. Of the five shortlisted applicants, two were women and both were deemed appointable. Both declined; one citing the high teaching workload as unattractive (Action 2.2.10).

While exploring how to increase the number of female applicants for academic posts, it was suggested that the language used in advertisements might be inadvertantly discouraging such applicants:

Table 2.2.3 Gender equality and academic recruitment

Year	Competition	Applicants			Shortlisted			Appointed		
		F	M	%F	F	M	%F	F	M	%F
2017/18	Professor of Computer Science	2	25	7%	0	7	0%	0	2	0%
	Lecturer in Computer Science	7	15	32%	4	3	57%	0	1	0%
	Lecturer in Computer Science	4	24	14%	0	7	0%	0	1	0%
2018/19	Lecturer in Computer Science (x2)	9	44	17%	2	7	22%	1	1	50%
	Lecturer in Computer Science (BA Psychology)	7	12	37%	3	3	50%	1	0	100%
	Lecturer in Computer Science (BA Digital Humanities)	8	17	32%	2	4	33%	1	0	100%
	Lecturer in Computer Science	0	6	0%	0	1	0%	0	1	0%
Total		37	143	21%	11	32	26%	3	6	33%

Note: No recruitment in 2019/2020.

> *"... can write a job advert in a way that discourages women from applying – it's the language you use ..."*

Consequently, the school will adopt gender neutral language and seek to use gender decoders when creating advertisements for academic and research positions (Action 2.2.2). Furthermore, we will actively target female applicants for all posts (Action 2.2.3).

ACTION 2.2.2: Improve advertising text

Improve the advertising text for staff positions to make it more appealing to females. ☞

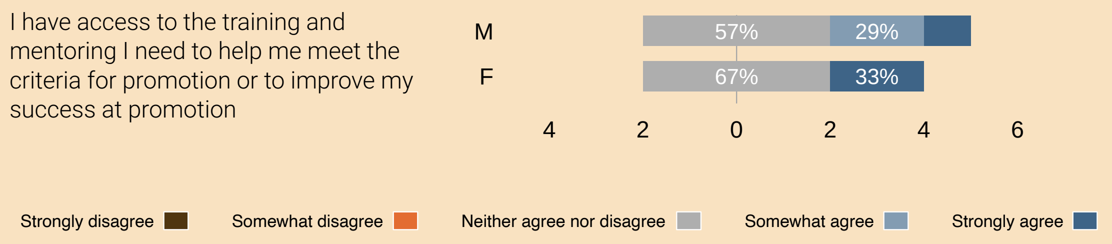
ACTION 2.2.3: Target suitable female academics and researchers

Actively target suitable female academics and researchers to apply for vacant school posts. ☞

In the period from 2017 to 2020, 21% of research appointments in CSIT were female. This is similar to the proportion of female PhD holders in Computer Science, globally.

The survey revealed that researchers remained unconvinced of adequate training and

Figure 2.2.1 Access to training and mentoring needed for promotion (Researchers)



mentoring opportunities towards promotion (Figure 2.2.1); for researchers, promotion implies either a higher researcher grade (e.g. Senior Research Fellow), or a permanent academic position.

In the focus group, researchers requested help be made available with personal development plans (Action 2.2.4).

ACTION 2.2.4: Support researchers with personal development plan

Research supervisors and PIs will actively mentor and encourage postdoctoral researchers towards academic careers, by helping them to create a personal development plan. ☞

The staff focus group highlighted the need to allow applicants to account for gaps in their CVs — particularly related to maternity leave and caring responsibilities.

> *"There isn't a guideline, ... that says, look if you have had a family break of any kind, ... you have this opportunity to describe it ... so that if you have gaps in your CV, you can explain them, because gaps in a CV are a red flag if they're not explained."*

Consequently, the school will accept 'Leave Statements' as part of its recruitment process (Action 2.2.5).

ACTION 2.2.5: Consider leave statements

Include an invitation in recruitment adverts for applicants to provide an appropriate leave statement to be considered by a selection committee. ☞

c Reflecting on academic promotion in your institution, answer the following:

	Yes	No	N/A
Academic promotion processes, including eligibility criteria, are managed centrally by the institution	☒	☐	☐

If you answered 'no', please comment on the department's role in academic promotions processes. If you answered 'not applicable', as prescribed promotion pathways are not in place in your institution, provide comment and reflection on alternative routes for academic career progression.

d Provide three years of data on application and success rates for promotion by gender and grade and present results from staff consultation by gender. Where data suggests opportunity for improvement, comment and reflect

As discussed on Page 42, only one call for promotion (2018/19) was issued from 2017 to 2019, resulting in no successful candidates (Table 2.2.4).

Table 2.2.4 Promotion applications and outcome to Senior Lecturer (2017-2020)

	Applicants		Successful		Success rates	
Year	F	M	F	M	F	M
2018/2019	0	2	0	0	0%	0%

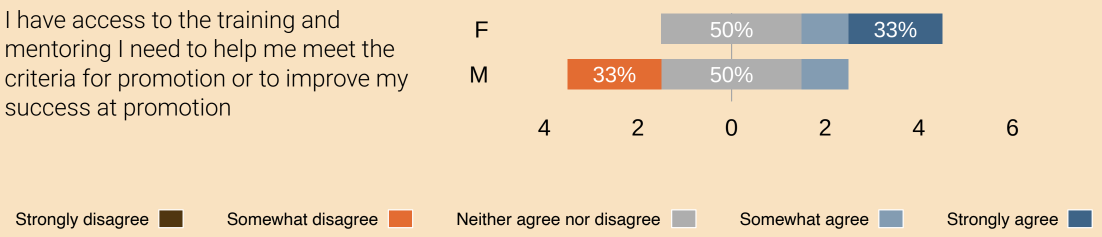
UCC had no promotion schemes to SL, to Professor (Scale 2) or Progression across the Merit Bar from 2016-2020.

Both the staff survey and focus groups revealed that staff are unhappy with the lack of promotion opportunities. Many respondents felt that the promotion process and criteria are neither transparent nor fair.

> *"There is no promotion scheme... It seems to be an impossible process to ... become a professor in UCC. I've kind of given up hope, to be honest."*

> *"In essence, there is no realistic prospect of promotion whatsoever... "*

Figure 2.2.2 Access to training and mentoring needed for promotion (Academics)



> *"I don't think I'll ever get a [more senior] position, ... I'm never going to get one of those because they do not align with my area of expertise."*

Since the consultation, academic progression and promotion schemes underwent a review in 2022. A call for progression across the merit bar opened in 2022. Calls for promotion to SL will open in early 2023 and to Professor (Scale 2) in 2024.

It was decided that a mentoring scheme to support colleagues seeking promotion would benefit all staff and would encourage female staff, in particular, to engage with the system (Action 2.2.6).

ACTION 2.2.6: Academic mentoring scheme

Create a mentoring and support scheme for academic staff who seek promotion. ☞

e Reflecting on opportunities for staff development reviews, answer the following:

	Yes	No
The institution operates a development review process, or equivalent, for academic and research staff	☒	☐

If you answered 'yes', comment and reflect on the implementation of this institution-level process in the department. This should include:

- data on uptake by gender;
- results from staff consultation presented by gender;

+ information on any additional department-level opportunities for staff to discuss professional development.

If you answered 'no', provide detail on department-level opportunities for staff to discuss professional development, including data on uptake by gender and results from staff consultation presented by gender.

UCC operates a Performance Development and Review System (Performance Development Review System (PDRS)), which applies to all staff, except for those with less than 50% FTE, less than a year left on a contract, staff on probation, on long term sick leave, or within two years of retirement. As part of the process, staff can discuss their development needs with their line manager. The process did not operate from 2017 to 2020; it was scheduled to restart in 2019, but this was further postponed due to Covid-19 restrictions in 2019 and 2020.

The staff survey revealed that the majority of academic staff were aware of the PDRS process (100% female, 80% male). However, the majority of research staff were unaware of the process (Figure 2.2.3). The survey data suggests that the female academic staff respondent was satisfied with the opportunity to engage with the HoS on performance and development, approximately 15% of male academic staff are not satisfied (neutral to or disagree with) with those opportunities (Figure 2.2.4).

Figure 2.2.3 Awareness of the Performance Development Review System

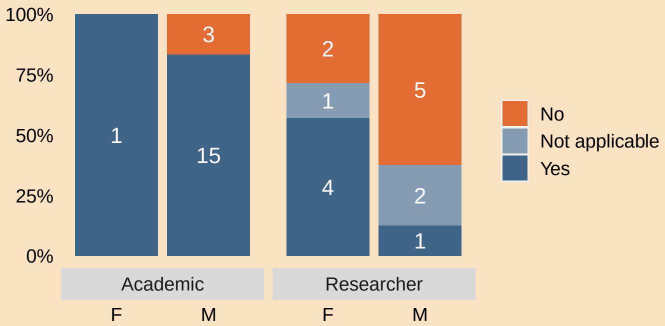
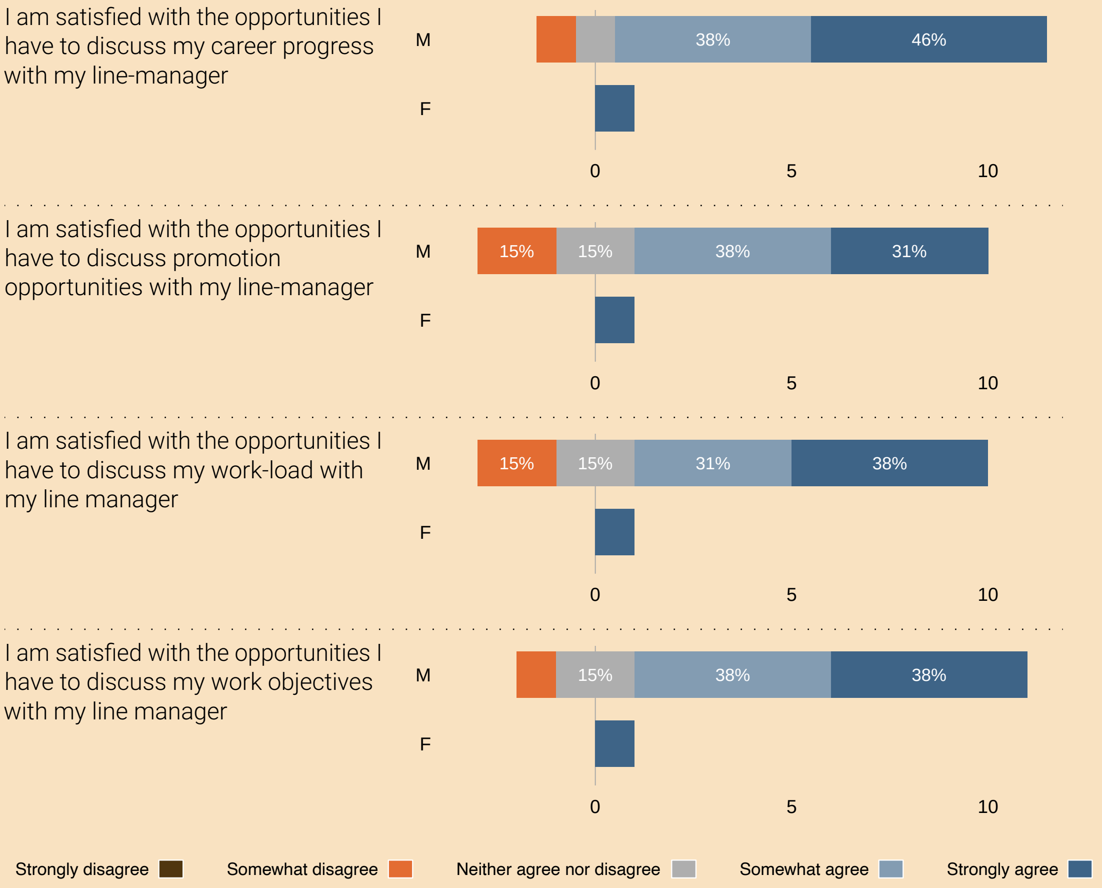


Figure 2.2.4 Academic career development opportunities



Comments on the PDRS process during the academic staff focus group were mixed:

> *"The only conversations that I have with a line manager or head of department would be [about teaching schedules] ..."*

> *"... he was very helpful. He tried to map out where are your weaknesses? [and supported me to develop in those areas]"*

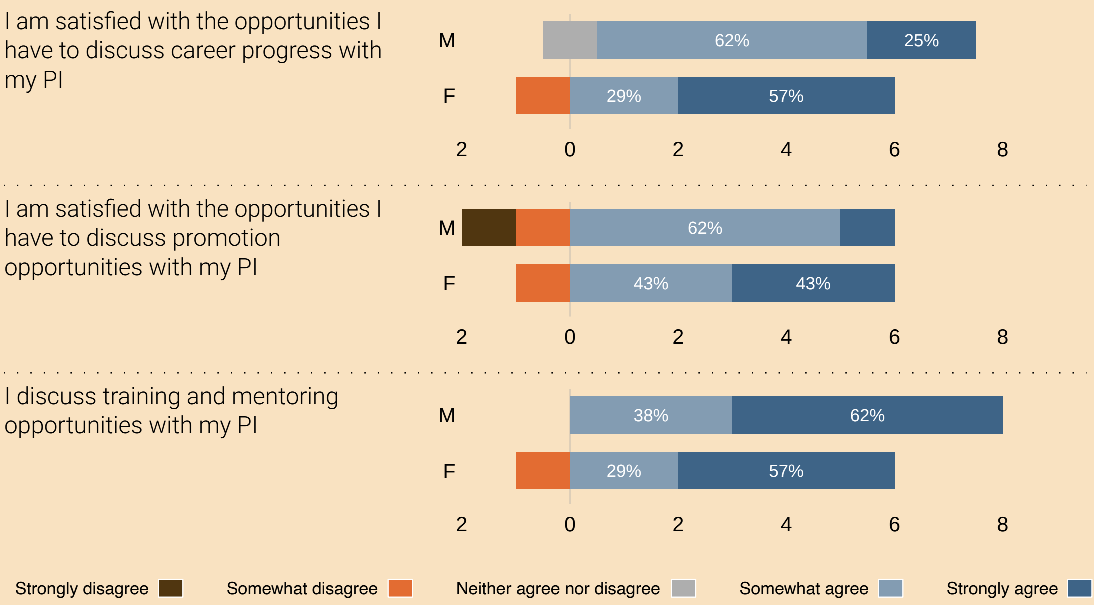
It is hoped that Action 2.2.7 would address these concerns.

ACTION 2.2.7: Restart PDRS process

Restart Performance Development Review System (PDRS) for all staff in the school. ☞

Researcher feedback from the staff survey and focus groups was mixed (Figure 2.2.5). The survey data indicated that approximately 70% of respondents never had a 'development needs' meeting with their line manager (PI). Approximately 90% have no personal development plan, 90% have no training objectives and 67% of those who do, consider that they are not meeting their training objectives. Nevertheless, respondents commended the development opportunities available within UCC and felt supported by the school to avail of those opportunities (Figure 2.2.6).

Figure 2.2.5 Support for researcher career planning

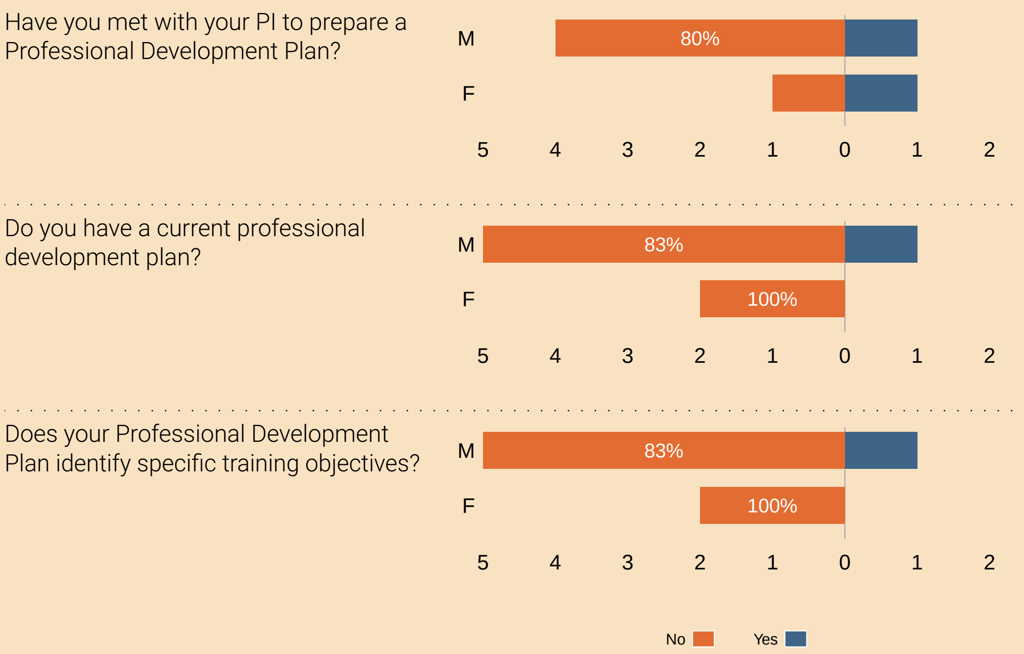


Overall, evidence suggests that many academic and research staff are unhappy with career development opportunities and supports (Action 2.2.7).

f Comment and reflect on department engagement with institution-level supports for academic and research staff career progression as well as any department-level support available. This should include results from staff consultation presented by gender and may include, but is not limited to, support given to staff to:

- apply for research funding;
- develop excellence in teaching and learning.

Figure 2.2.6 Research staff career development



Comments and Reflections on Institution-level Supports for Career Progression

UCC provides training and development programmes for academic and research staff. These include personal and professional development, management and leadership development, and staff wellbeing, which are coordinated by HR, the Office of the VP for Research and Innovation (OVPRI), and the Office of the VP for Teaching and Learning. Table 2.2.5 shows the uptake of development opportunities by academic staff in the report period.

Irish universities consider postdoctoral staff as 'research trainees.' UCC provides many training and development opportunities via its PostDoc Development Hub.[8] Table 2.2.6 shows these courses and their uptake in the report period. The data do not indicate how many researchers availed of these, but the uptake is limited, particularly among male researchers.

[8] https://www.ucc.ie/en/hr/research/devhub/

Table 2.2.5 Training uptake by academic staff by gender

Year	Course	F	M
2017/18	Innovative Problem Solving	0	2
	Retirement Planning: Lifestyle, wellbeing, and legal aspects	0	1
	Networking with Confidence	0	1
2018/19	The Successful Team Leader	0	1
	Effective Presentation Skills	0	1
	Retirement Planning: Financial Aspects	0	1
	Time Management	0	2
	Post Doc Development Hub	0	1
2019/20	The Successful Team Leader	0	2
	Post Doc Development Hub	1	6
	Recruitment and Selection Training	0	1
	Flu Vaccines	0	3
	Mardyke Physical Activity Classes	0	1
	Money Skills for Life	1	1
Total		2	24

Table 2.2.6 Training uptake by research staff, by gender

Year	Course	F	M
2017/18	Developing and consolidating your career	2	0
	Project Management Part 1	1	0
	Project Management Part 2	1	0
	Grant Writing	1	0
	Leading a Research Team	1	0
	Research Data Management	1	0
2018/19	Lean Yellow Belt Training	1	1
	Active Listening Skills	1	0
	Communicating With Impact - Managers/Team Leaders	1	1
	Developing Positive and Assertive Communication Skills	0	1

Table 2.2.6 Training uptake by research staff, by gender (continued)

	Engaging People Who Are Anxious, Distressed, Angry	0	2
	Identifying and Responding To Students In Distress	0	1
	Managing Stress In The Workplace	0	1
	The Effective Employee	0	4
	Time Management	0	2
	Unconscious Bias Training	0	2
	Maximising Professional Effectiveness	1	0
	Grant Writing	0	1
	Presentation Skills	1	10
	Commercial Awareness and Knowledge Transfer	0	1
	Data Management	2	0
	Funding Your Research	1	0
	Leading a Research Team	1	0
	Managing Yourself Through Change	1	0
	Statistics for Researchers	1	0
	Teaching and Learning	1	0
2019/20	Change Management	0	1
	Communicating With Impact - Managers/Team Leaders	1	0
	Critical Thinking For Effective Decisions	0	1
	Engaging People Who Are Anxious, Distressed, Angry	1	0
	Flu Vaccines	0	3
	Introduction To Project Management	1	0
	Money Skills For Life	1	1
	Networking Using Drama and Improvisation Techniques	0	1
	Remote Working Workshop - Employee	1	0
	The Successful Team Leader	0	2
	Time Management	0	1
	UCC Health and Wellness Workshops	1	0
	Winning The Stress Game - Stress Management Info Session	1	1
	Project Management	2	0
	Statistics for Researchers	1	0

Table 2.2.6 Training uptake by research staff, by gender (continued)

	Funding Your Research	1	0
	Making That Transition	1	0
	Presentation Skills for Research Staff	1	1
	Motivation Skills for Research Staff	1	0
	Communication Skills for Researchers	1	0
Total		34	29

There was a marked difference between female and male staff taking up training opportunities (Figure 2.2.7). The female respondant was happy with the training opportunities and their relevance, the male staff were less happy. They had a lack of awareness, relevance and availability of training opportunities, a perceived lack of support by line manager to participate in training, a perceived lack of opportunity to attend conferences, and some reported a lack of opportunity to present their work to school peers.

Research staff have a more positive view and more balance can be seen between male and female respondents (Figure 2.2.7). A desire was expressed for better communication on training and development opportunities:

> *"It's important to keep training to keep up to date. I'd like more open discussion around training needs and requirements."*

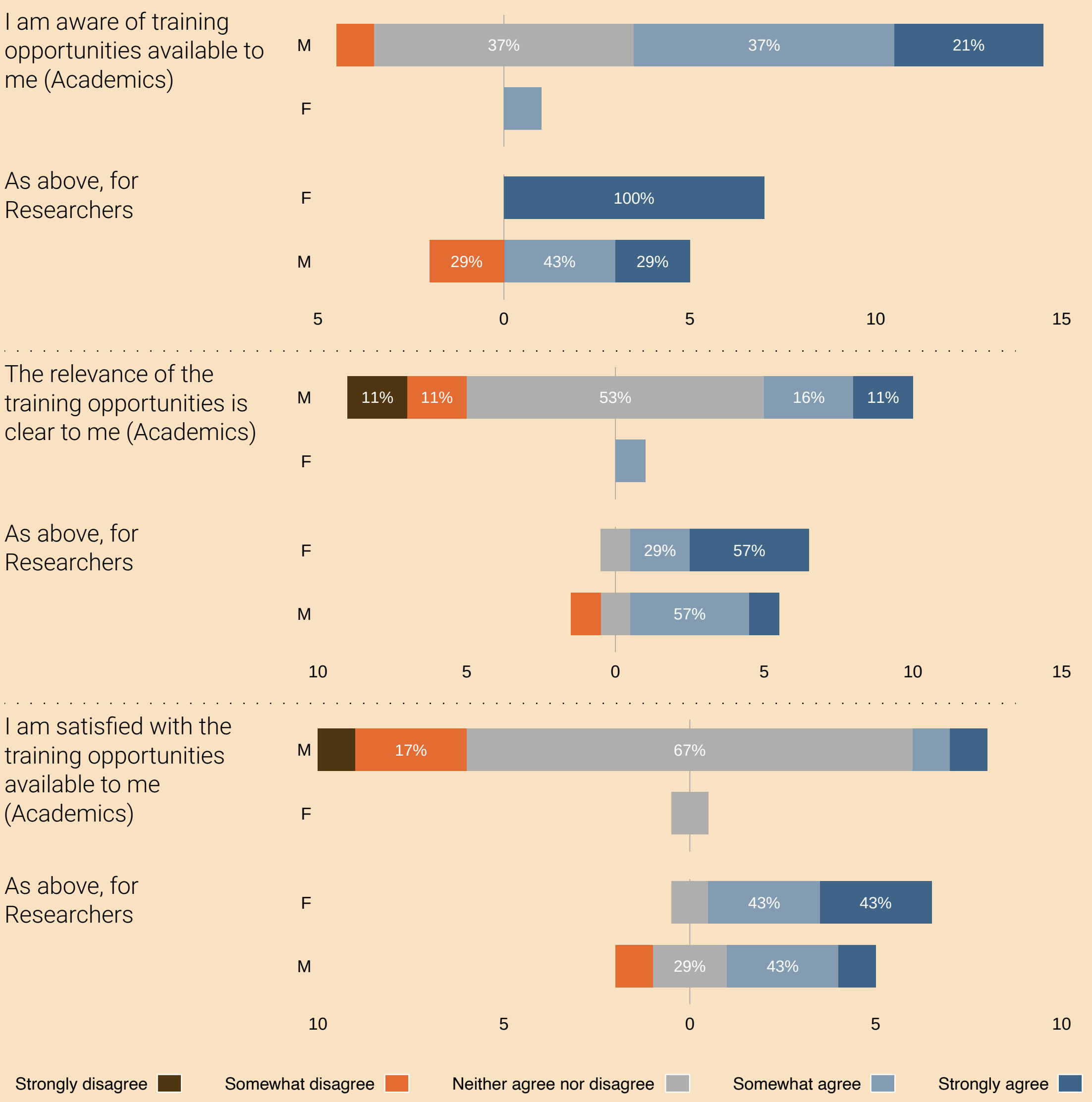
> *"Unfortunately, I have never heard or seen any email where funding for training has been circulated or promoted."*

Academic staff in the focus group were satisified with the school supports and with training offered centrally, but they perceived the uptake to be low. They suggested that the school should echo these opportunities to the staff:

> *"Those kind of courses [like CIRTL – Centre for Integration of Research, Teaching, and Learning] should be advertised by the department ... courses that we can improve ... project management skills, soft skills, hard skills ... I think that would really benefit us going forward."*

Research staff in the focus group would like to see more support for research staff development at school level. Currently, support for career development mainly comes

Figure 2.2.7 Training awareness



from their respective research centres and groups. Consequently, not all researchers may have the same opportunities; researchers who were not part of a centre or large group reported being isolated. As mentioned, the PDRS will restart (Action 2.2.7), which will incorporate career development for research staff, and the PDRS will also serve as a mechanism to make staff aware of training opportunities.

Support for Research Funding Applications

Figure 2.2.8 presents results regarding perceived importance, opportunities, and support for research funding, disaggregated by staff category (academic, research) and gender. Overall, staff perceived opportunities to apply for research funding is important to their professional development. The data revealed a number of issues.

Figure 2.2.8 Support for funding

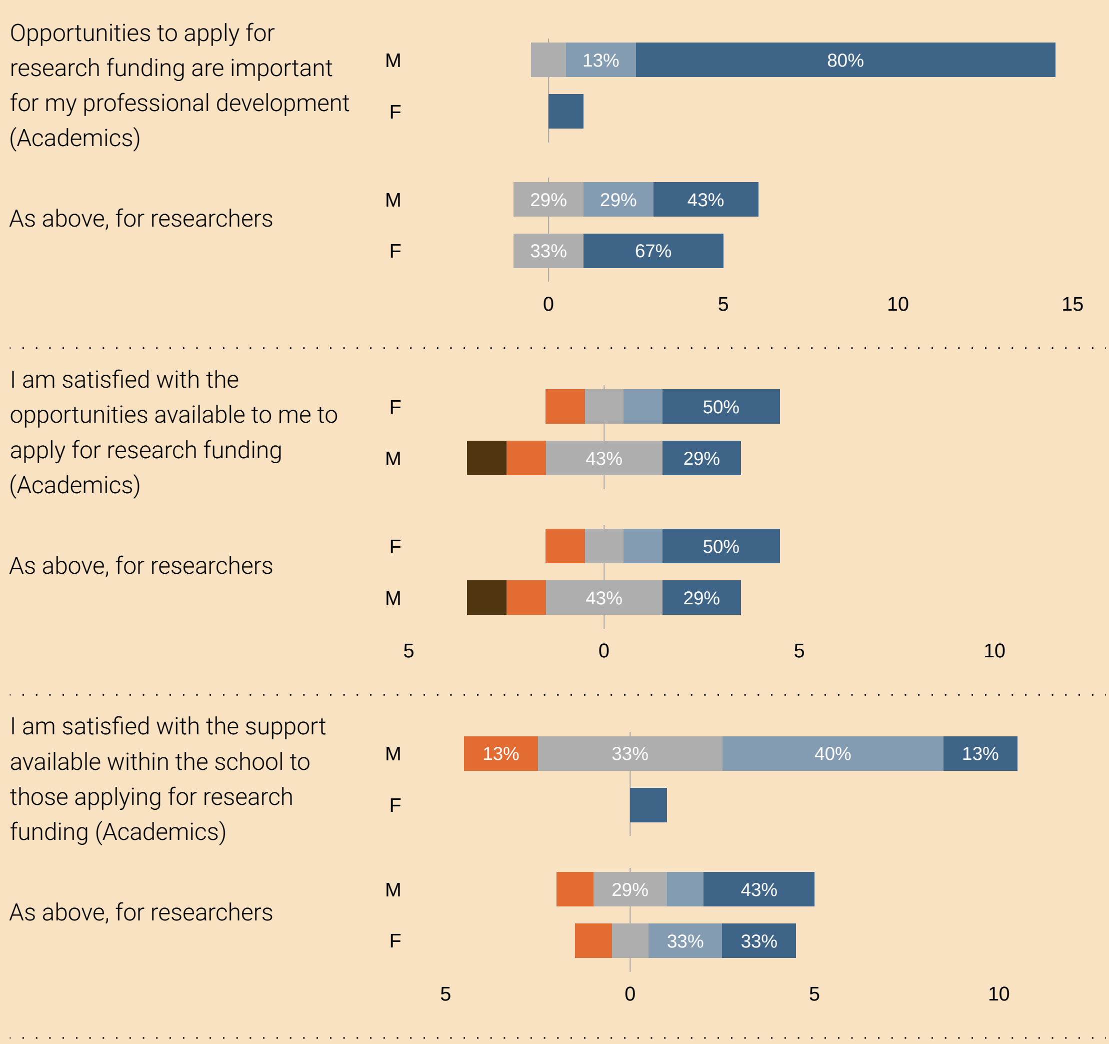
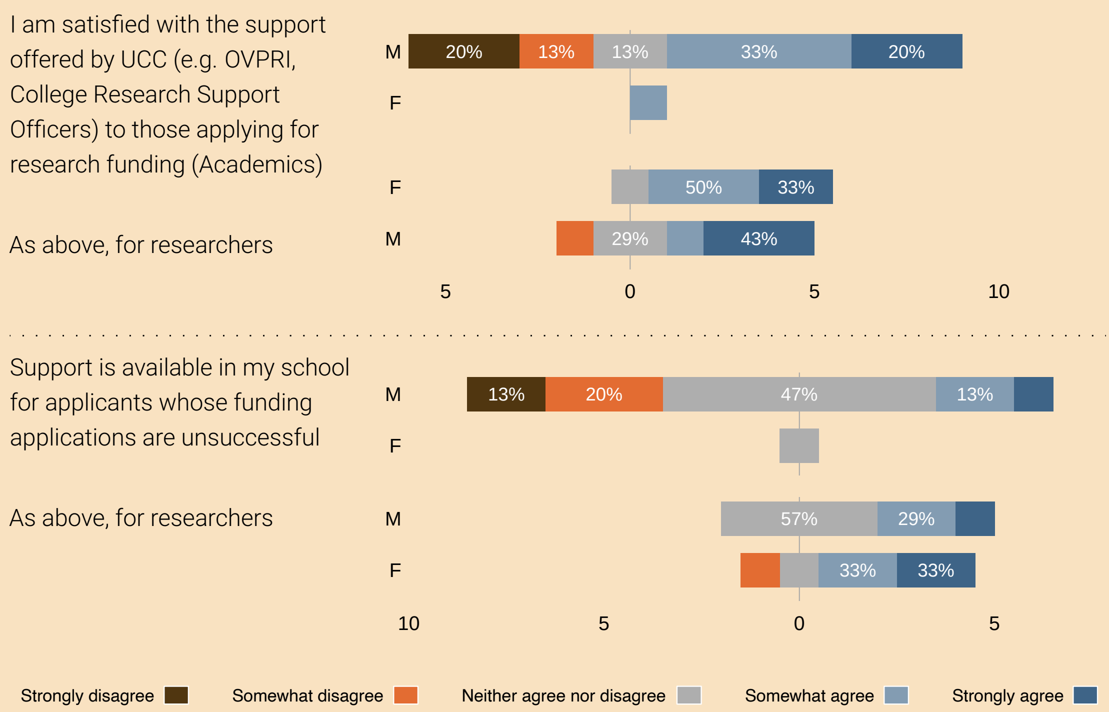


Figure 2.2.8 Support for funding (continued)



While available opportunities to apply for funding were mostly satisfactory for both academics and researchers, a number of academics and researchers were dissatisfied. Further, most respondents also were satisfied with the support available within the school to apply for funding, a small number respondents were not. Less satisfied were a number of male academics with the support provided by the university, for example through the OVPRI and the college. Finally, there is some room for improvement to provide support to those whose funding applications were not successful. While several respondents answered neutral (neither agree/disagree), male academics in particular found this lacking.

Success in attracting research funding is a key factor in academic career progression for both researchers and academics, and in response the school will create a programme to support staff before, during, and after the funding application process (Action 2.2.8).

ACTION 2.2.8: Research funding support programme

Create a programme to support school staff with research funding applications. ☞

Support for Development of Excellence in Teaching and Learning

A qualification in teaching and learning is essential for promotion from Lecturer to Senior Lecturer so the school encourages all academic staff to avail of the courses offered by Centre for Integration of Research, Teaching, and Learning (CIRTL).

Academic survey respondents were broadly satisfied with access to and support for equipment and digital tools, for teaching and research. The IT support group are held in high esteem.

Research staff focus group respondents would like to have more clarity on opportunities to participate in tutoring, lecturing and other academic duties (Action 2.2.9).

> **ACTION 2.2.9: Opportunities for research staff to engage in school academic activities**
>
> Create a policy, outlining a set of defined opportunities and an application procedures to allow researchers to participate in the specified academic activities. ☞

g Comment and reflect on how workload is allocated and managed in the department (e.g. via a workload allocation model). This should include information on how the breadth of academic and research roles and responsibilities are captured in workload planning and allocation and results from staff consultation presented by gender.

Workload Model and Allocation

Academic staff workload includes teaching, research, and administration. Research staff primarily conduct research, but may also be asked to undertake light administrative tasks and/or contribute to teaching. Research workload for academic staff is somewhat self-allocated and varies by staff member. Workload is allocated by the HoS to cover core teaching and administrative duties. New staff are assigned a reduced teaching load for their first year to enable them to develop their research agenda. There is very limited recognition of research workload in the school's workload distribution scheme. This can result in a higher workload for research active staff.

Workload allocation for research staff depends on their line manager and on their ambition.

Figure 2.2.9 Workload before and during Covid-19, by gender

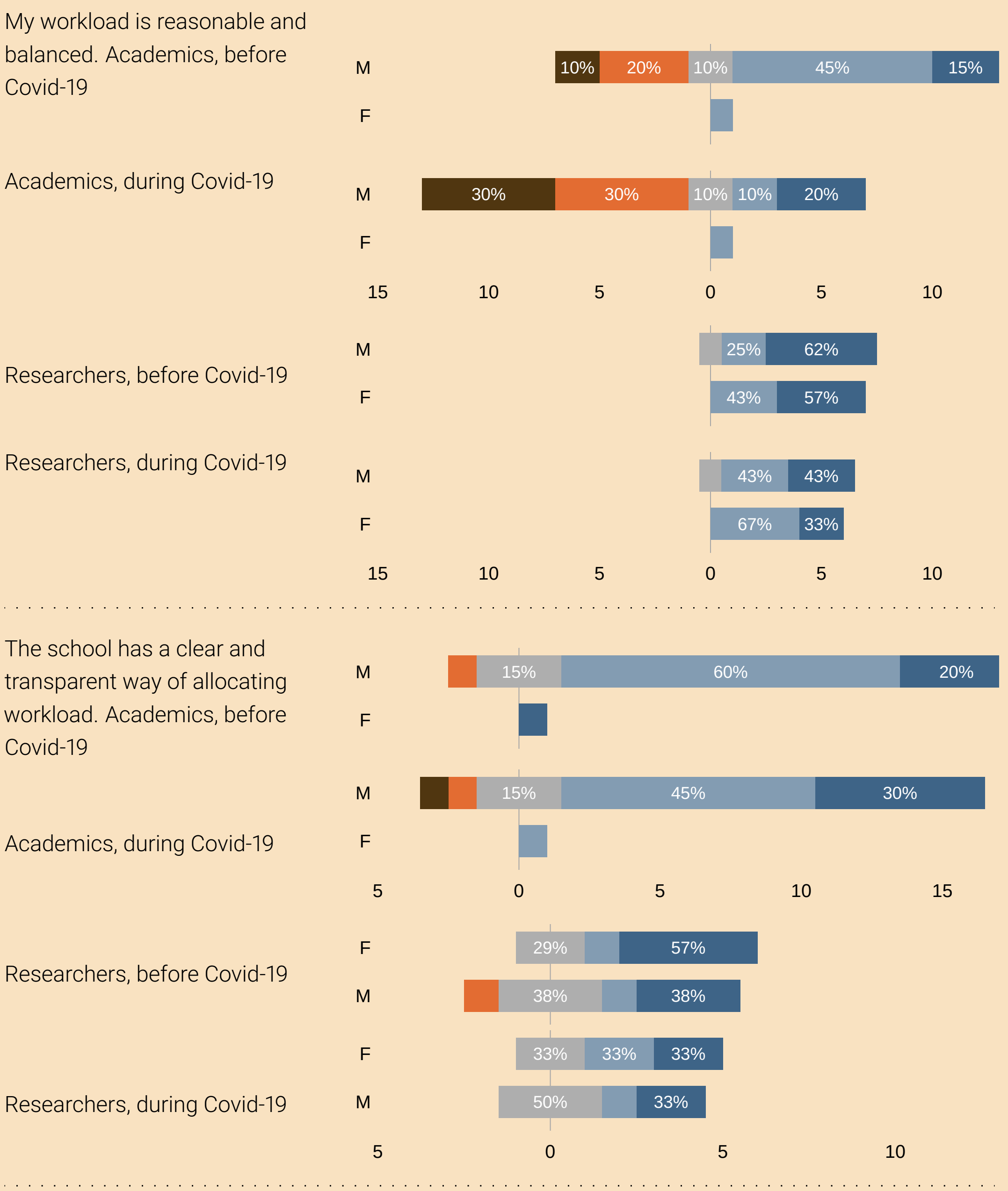
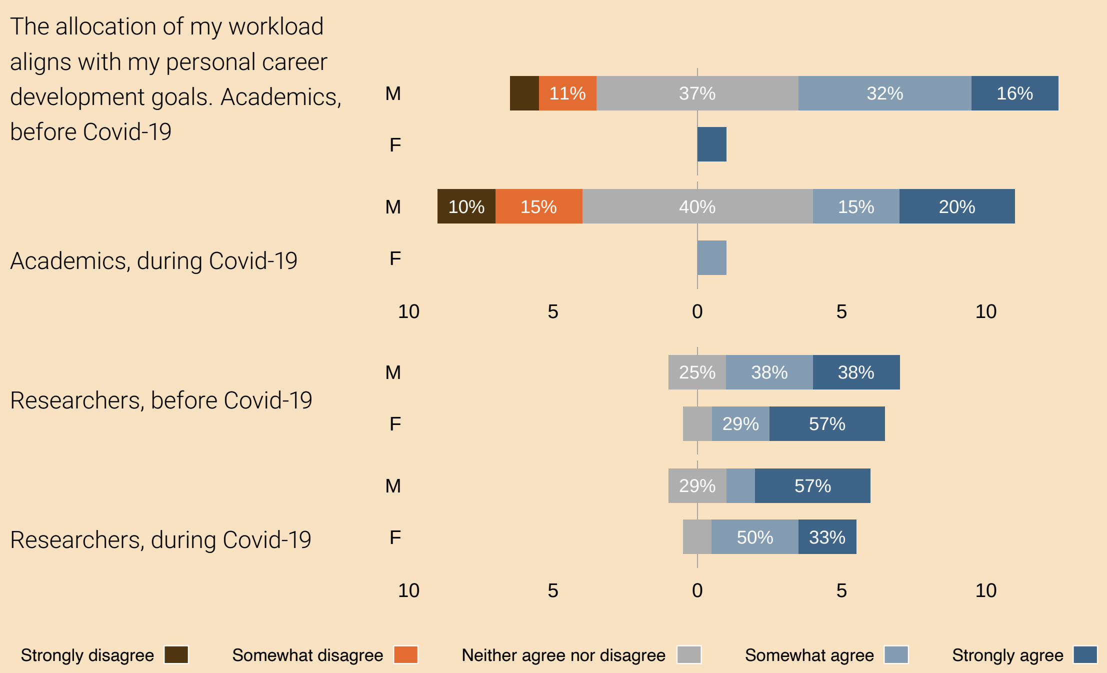


Figure 2.2.9 Workload before and during Covid-19, by gender (continued)

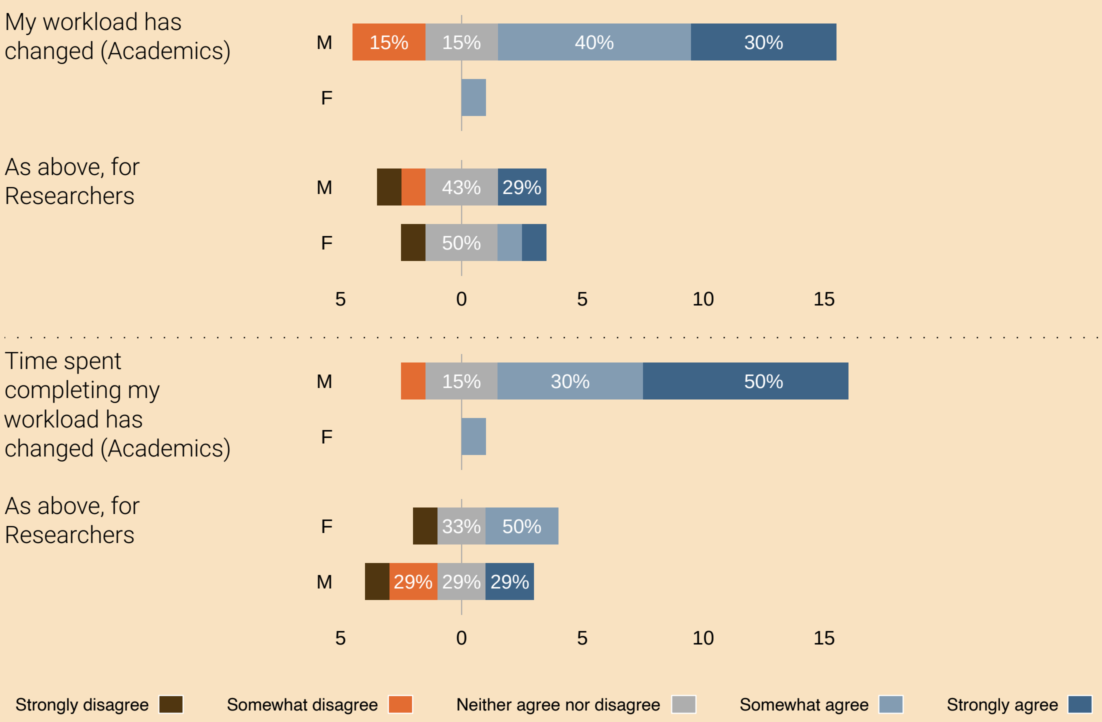


The female academic felt that her workload was reasonable and balanced, that the scheme was transparent way, supporting her career goals. This did not change during the Covid-19 period (Figure 2.2.9 and Figure 2.2.10). Just over half of the male academics felt their workload allocation was reasonable and balanced; the majority felt that the allocation was clear and transparent. Only half said that the workload allocation aligned with their personal career development goals. Most male respondents felt that their workload was not balanced and had changed since the pandemic started. In the academic focus group, some colleagues commented on the ever-increasing number of administrative tasks, the scheduling of meetings, and the timing of tasks that may clash with caring responsibilities.

> *"Caring responsibilities are not considered when it comes to timing of meetings or academic responsibilities e.g. lecturing / labs. It is also not considered for workload."*

Both female and male research staff respondents felt that their workload was reasonable and balanced (Figure 2.2.9), whereas 50% of female and male staff did not consider it to be clear and transparent. The majority of staff felt that their workload aligned with career development goals. However, problems remain:

Figure 2.2.10 Perceived changes to workload since Covid-19



"If anything, the workload has increased considerably in the past 16 months [but] teamwork is good."

In response, the school will review its workload model (Action 2.2.10).

ACTION 2.2.10: Review workload model

Review the school workload model for academic staff. ☞

3 Embedding policy, practice and supports to advance professional, managerial and support staff careers

Professional, Managerial, and Support (PMS) staff as discussed in this section also includes research support staff, i.e. members of staff who perform primarily administrative tasks.

a Reflecting on recruitment practices in the department, answer the following:

	Yes	No
Recruitment to PMS posts in the department adheres to institutional policy on recruitment, which includes gender-balanced panels and training for assessors.	☒	☐

If you answered 'no', please comment.

b Provide three years of data on application, shortlist, and appointment rates for recruitment by gender and grade. Where data suggests opportunity for improvement, comment and reflect. Include any other relevant information relating to recruitment processes and practice for professional, managerial and support staff in the department.

Gender specific data for selection committees and applications for the process of appointing PMS staff were not available at the time of application. However, partial records were gathered within CSIT (Tables 2.3.1, 2.3.2).

Over a three-year period, there was a relatively even distribution of genders across those shortlisted. There is greater gender diversity among applicants for research PMS posts. However a challenge exists in attracting a gender-diverse pool of applicants to the school office (5 F) and systems administration posts (5 M). A male staff member was recruited to the school's administrative group in 2018 but has recently moved to a research PMS role. Although 12 PMS staff took the EDI survey, only 1-3 responses were received for recruitment questions. Those that answered were content with the recruitment process.

The PMS working group discussed the causation, and mechanisms to address, gender imbalance. These included targeted recruitment strategies and making use of a gender

Table 2.3.1 Gender composition of selection committees for PMS Appointments (2017-2020)

Year	Competition	Chair Person		Board Members	
		F	M	F	M
Administrative (School)					
2018	Senior Executive Assistant	1	0	1	1
2020	Executive Assistant	1	0	1	1
Systems Administrative Support					
2019	Computing Systems Engineer	1	0	0	3
Research Support					
2017/18	Systems & HPC Lead, Insight	1	0	2	4
2018/19	Senior Research Coordinator (EU Programme Manager), Insight	0	1	0	1
	Research Support Officer	*	*	*	*
	Senior Research Coordinator (Advance CRT Programme Manager)	0	1	2	0
2019 /20	Research Assistant (ADVANCE CRT)	0	1	1	1
	Senior Research Coordinator (CONFIRM)	0	1	1	1
	Research Coordinator (Insight)	0	1	1	1

* Data not available

language software to check for bias[9] in advertisements. The new EDI implementation committee (EDIIC) will review the language used in advertisements to provide gender-neutral language (Action 2.2.2, Page 48).

Furthermore, the PMS workgroup discussed how to convey the EDI-friendly ethos of the school. Action 2.3.1 was proposed to review all school materials (images and text) to convey the flexible, inclusive and collegiate nature of the school.

Periods of leave can have a negative impact on the career of women. The workgroup discussed how this situation may have worsened since the Covid-19 pandemic. As such, Action 2.2.5 (Page 49) was proposed to invite individuals to voluntarily account for documented leave, caring responsibilities, and pandemic-related gaps in their CV.

[9] `https://capd.mit.edu/resources/gender-decoder/`

Table 2.3.2 Recruitment of PMS staff by competition and gender (2017-2020)

Year	Competition	Applicants			Shortlisted			Appointed	
		F	M	%F	F	M	%F	F	M
Administrative (School)									
2018	Senior Executive Assistant	6	1	86%	3	1	75%	0	1
2020	Executive Assistant	6	0	100%	4	0	100%	1	0
Systems Administrative Support									
2019	Computing Systems Engineer	*	*	*	*	*	*	*	1
Research Support									
2017/18	Systems & HPC Lead, Insight	0	1	0%	0	1	0%	0	1
2018/19	Senior Research Coordinator (EU Programme Manager), Insight	0	2	0%	0	1	0%	0	1
	Research Support Officer	1	0	100%	1	0	100%	1	0
	Senior Research Coordinator (ADVANCE CRT Programme Manager)	(8)		–	2	2	0%	0	1
2019/20	Research Support Officer	3	10	23%	3	10	23%	1	0
	Senior Research Coordinator (ADVANCE CRT)	2	3	40%	2	3	40%	0	1
	Research Coordinator (Insight)	4	1	80%	4	1	80%	Not filled	Not filled

* Data not available
(n) gender not recorded; total number n reported

The PMS workgroup discussions highlighted that the advertising template for research PMS positions is the same as that for academic researchers. The standard listed application criteria are not relevant to research PMS applicants, for example, a list of publications. This may deter suitably qualified potential applicants from applying for such research PMS positions. In order to prevent applicant confusion regarding what research PMS roles entail, potentially limiting the pool of applicants, Action 2.3.1 is proposed.

ACTION 2.3.1: Revise PMS application forms locally

Provide guidelines for advertisements for research PMS posts. ☞

Finally, part of Action 2.1.8 (Page 38) provides an opportunity for female undergraduate students to gain relevant work experience. This includes within the school's systems administration group, which could both provide an opportunity for female undergraduates students to gain experience and introduce some gender diversity to the systems administration team.

c Reflecting on progression in your institution, answer the following:

Career progression opportunities for PMS staff are centrally managed by the institution (e.g. internal vacancy competitions; regrading; promotions pathway).	Yes	No
	☒	☐

If you answered 'no', please comment on the department's role in career progression for professional, managerial and support staff.

All administrative promotions are handled centrally by UCC. The EDI survey and the PMS focus group indicated that most PMS staff have no interest in career progression. Some expressed a strong dissatisfaction with the lack of progression opportunities due to infrequent promotion calls and small quotas.

> *"I am not familiar with the promotion scheme. It does not apply to my case and therefore I have never expressed interest on it."*

> *"I think it's quite clear that this is a problem across UCC. And the unfortunate thing is, it means that UCC doesn't get the best from staff. People that are capable of doing more are not being given the opportunity to do that, and I think that's damaging to the whole institution."*

Internal vacancy competitions

Limited opportunities exist for progressing to senior grades via internal recruitment, usually requiring a move to a different unit. This was perceived as uncertainty and risk, since PMS staff are largely happy working within the school:

"We want to progress but [also] to remain in the School ... because, well, I'm happy here. And in order to [be] promoted, sometimes you need to go across campus and so that puts you off a bit because, you know, your well-being and being happy [are] very important."

"Moving from [one] department in the university to another department ... can cause issues. It's almost treated like you're starting a new job [with a period of] probation ... If you're looking for loans, mortgages, things like that ... It seems like a kind of short-sighted thing to just default onto people."

Promotion

PMS staff expressed strong views on the lack of promotion opportunities, which had lain dormant for a long time. In recent years regular promotional calls (every three years) have become the norm for PMS (and Academic) staff. The first of these calls was in 2019/2020, making 53 promotional posts available. No CSIT PMS staff member applied to this scheme. Another call has recently issued for 2022/2023.

Some female PMS staff were sceptical of the process, believing that interviewers lacked a first hand knowledge, or understanding, of the roles that applicants occupied at the time of application.

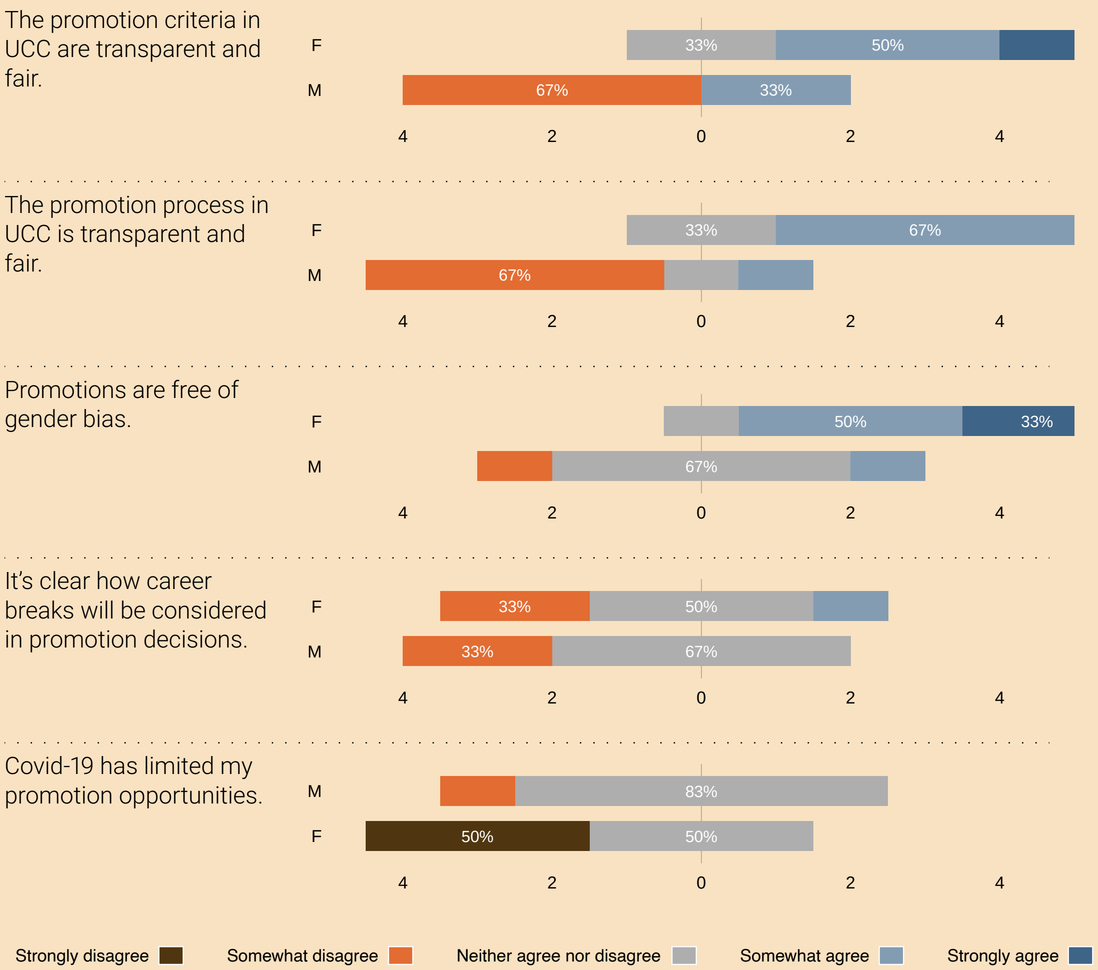
Promotion pathways

In the survey, PMSS were asked to reflect on the career progression opportunities (Figure 2.3.1). Apart from one male staff member, both genders agreed that promotions are free from gender bias. However, 2 females and 2 males were unsure how career breaks are considered in promotion decisions. The PMS Workgroup and focus group believed that the pandemic would likely have had a negative impact on promotion. This will be addressed with Action 2.2.5 (Page 49).

PMSS did express a desire for greater training and guidance on preparing for promotion. Given the range of diverse PMS jobs available across the university, in schools and in central administrative units, one participant felt that guidance on potential PMS career pathways within the institution would be useful, to assist staff in identifying where and how their skills and experience might be usefully redeployed and expanded. Others concurred with this view.

PMS staff training and career development will be discussed during PDRS meetings which will restart (Action 2.2.7).

Figure 2.3.1 Career progression process



d Reflecting on opportunities for staff development review, answer the following:

The institution operates a development review process, or equivalent, for PMS staff	**Yes**	**No**
	☒	☐

If you answered ‘yes’, comment and reflect on the implementation of this institution-level process in the department. This should include:

- data on uptake by gender;
- results from staff consultation presented by gender;

+ information on any additional department-level opportunities for staff to discuss professional development, where different to above (2.e).

If you answered 'no', provide detail on department-level opportunities for staff to discuss professional development, where different to above (2.e), including data on uptake by gender and results from staff consultation presented by gender.

Data uptake of development review process by gender

As mentioned on Page 52, the PDRS applies to all staff, and is due to resume in 2023 (Action 2.2.7). Table 2.3.3 indicates the line managers involved in the PDRS for Professional Management and Support Staff (PMSS).

Table 2.3.3 Performance Development Review Structure in CSIT

Role	Line managers who hold reviews
School PMS staff	School Manager
Systems administration PMS staff	Computing Systems Manager
Researcher PMS staff	Principal Investigators, Funded Investigators, RICU managers

Results from staff consultation presented by gender

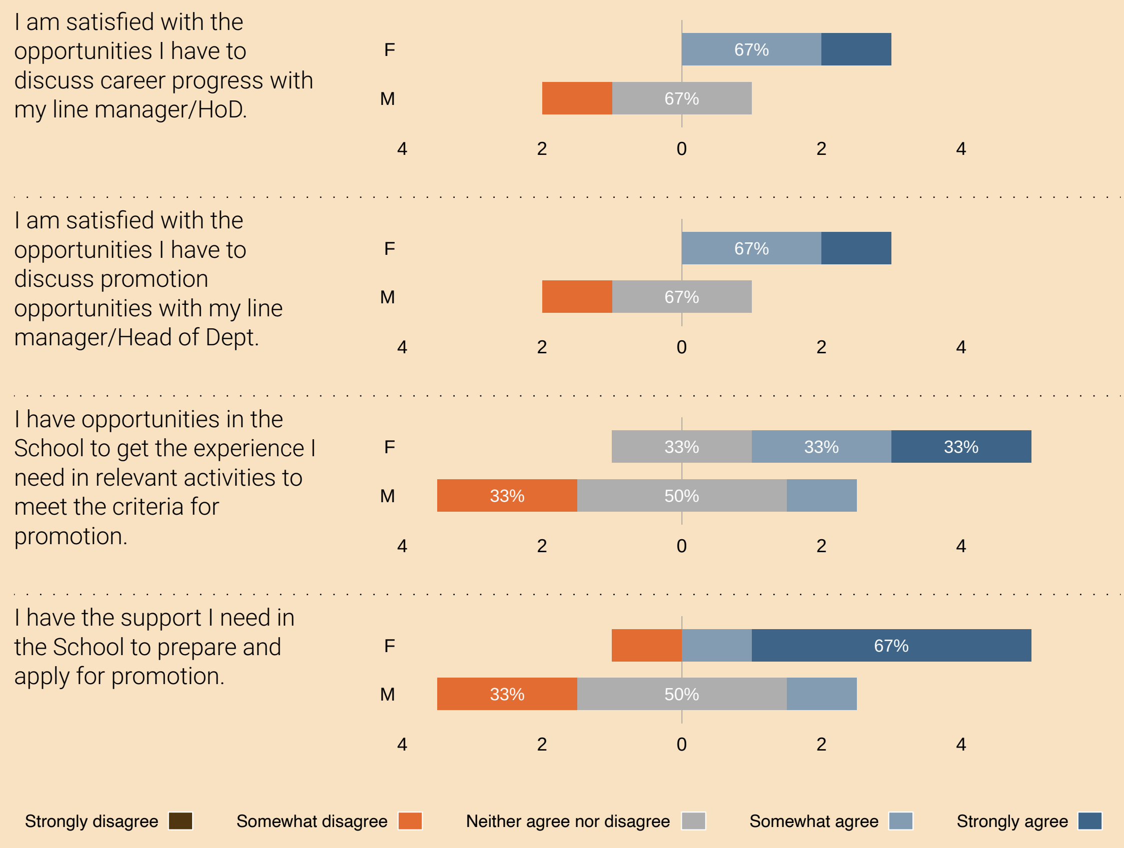
The PMS staff were asked, in the staff survey, to reflect on their opportunities to discuss career progress and promotion opportunities, Figure 2.3.2. Female staff were content with the opportunities available, there was some discontent amongst male PMS staff. Two male PMS staff members referred to a lack of opportunities within their roles to gain the experience required to meet promotion criteria.

> *"I think as well in the school there could be more done perhaps to allow staff to gain experience or to try different things, but in their roles."*

In the PMS focus group, despite the absence of formal reviews, participants reported strong satisfaction with the opportunities and support available to them to discuss their career/professional development with their line managers:

> *"our line manager is very open to talking about career opportunities but obviously she has a limit. She can't create promotion opportunities. She's very supportive and does her best."*

Figure 2.3.2 Departmental support for career progression



"There are opportunities to sit down with your line manager and get feedback. Because you know they're very very open, the door is always open. But I suppose they're also very restricted in what career path they can lay out for you and incentives to do well without promotional opportunities."

To provide better support for PMS staff in their professional development, Action 2.3.2 is proposed.

ACTION 2.3.2: Opportunities for professional experience

Provide PMS staff with regular opportunities for professional career development. ☞

Information on any additional department-level opportunities for staff to discuss professional development, where different to above (2.e)

PMS staff have expressed their desire for greater guidance and training for their professional and career development. We hope that the restarting of the PDRS (Action 2.2.7) will help in this regard.

e Comment and reflect on department engagement with institution-level supports for PMS staff career progression as well as any department-level support available, where different from above (2.f). This should include results from staff consultation presented by gender.

Although CSIT does not operate a formal policy of staff training for career development and progression, it raises awareness of training and progression opportunities. A wide range of training workshops are offered by the university, covering topics such as Team-

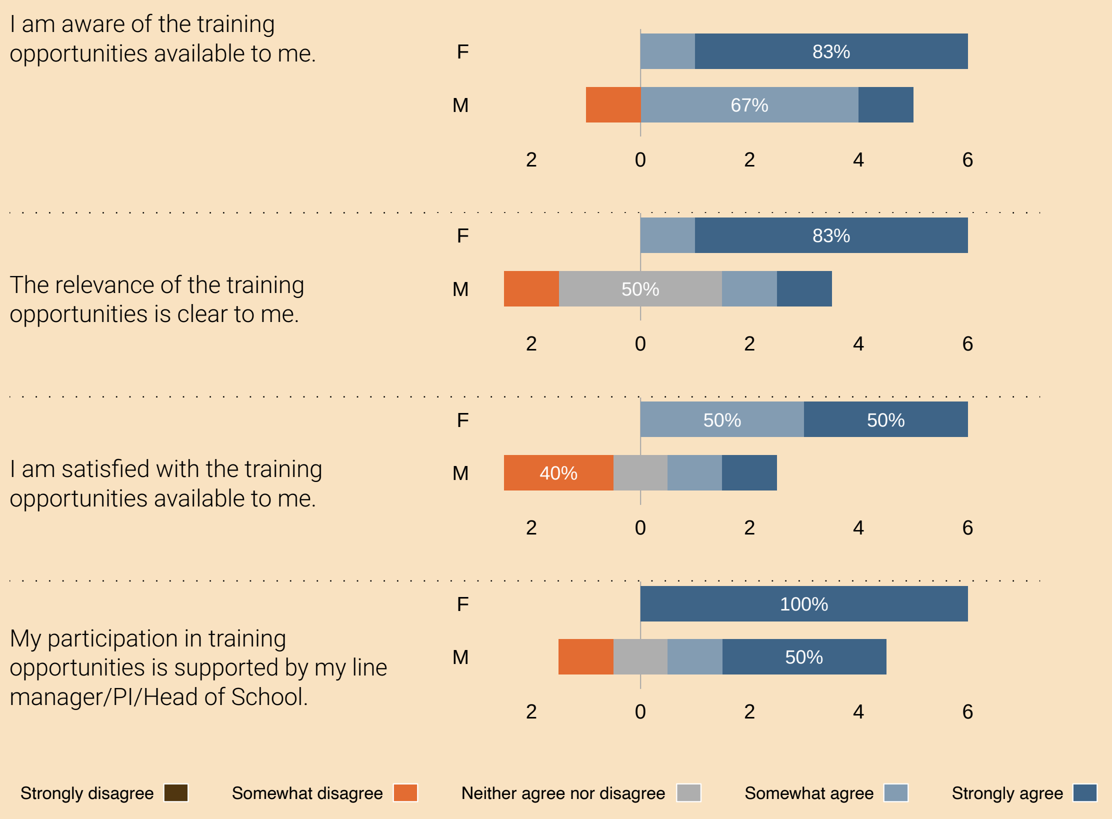
Table 2.3.4 Training uptake by PMS staff by gender

Year	Course	F	M
2017/18	Mental Health Awareness for Managers	1	1
	Inside Out Mindfulness: Working Mindfully	0	1
	Lean Yellow Belt Training	0	1
2018/19	Senior Leadership Development: Aspiring Leaders	0	1
	Innovative Problem Solving	0	1
	Innovative Problem Solving: Follow Up Session	0	1
	Lean Yellow Belt Training	0	1
	Mid Career Financial Planning	0	1
	Active Listening Skills	1	0
	The Effective Employee	5	0
2019/20	Engaging with People who are Angry, Anxious, or Panicked	1	0
	Remote Working Workshop: Employee	0	1
	Remote Working Workshop: Manager	0	1
	The Effective Employee	1	0
	You and Your MBTI Preferences During Covid-19	1	0
Total		10	10

work, Leadership Potential, Leadership and Strategic Direction, People Management and Supervision, Management and Delivery of Results, and more. Table 2.3.4 shows PMS staff engagement with these workshops in the 2017-2020 time period; on balance, there is an even uptake of opportunities among males and females.

PMS staff were asked in the staff survey to reflect on training supports for career progression with responses summarised in Figure 2.3.3. Of the 12 PMS respondents, 6 answered this set of questions. All female respondents were content with the training supports available. The male respondents expressed some minor discontentment.

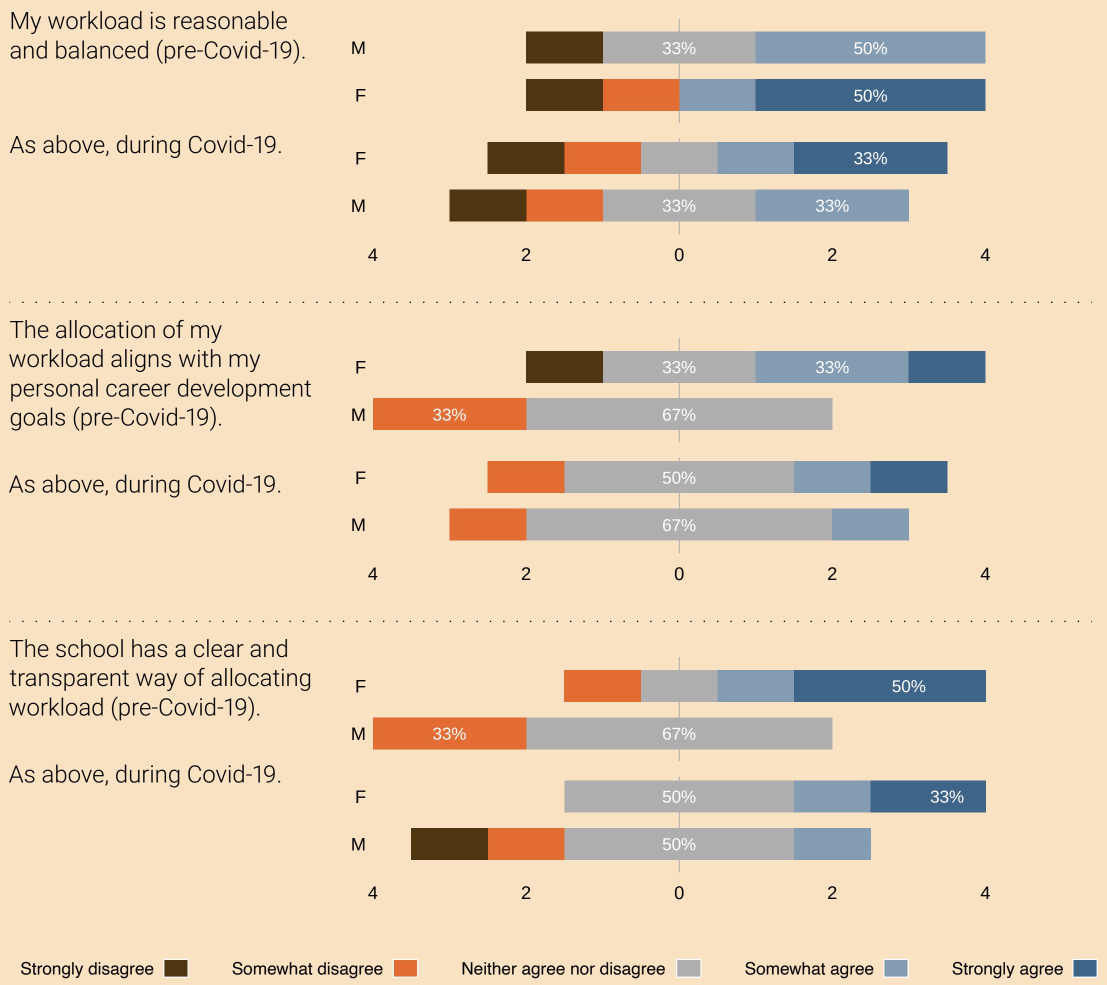
Figure 2.3.3 Training supports for PMS career progression



f Comment and reflect on how workload is distributed and managed. This should include information on how the breadth of professional, managerial and support roles and responsibilities are captured in workload planning and allocation and results from staff consultation presented by gender.

Non-research PMS staff workload is managed by the School Manager, subject to their specified responsibilities. The administrative support workload is distributed across several categories, including academic support, outreach and student recruitment, finance, HR, and health and safety. Workload is managed by the Computing Systems

Figure 2.3.4 Workload distribution, before Covid-19 and during, by gender



Manager based on function and matched to the expertise of the staff member. Functions include IT support, core systems/services, and teaching support.

The workload of the research PMS staff is managed by the general manager of one of the research centres (Table 2.1.2), or by a specific Principal Investigator (PI) in the case of smaller research units.

PMS staff were asked to reflect on their workload allocation (Figure 2.3.4), if it was transparently allocated and if it aligned with their career goals. Generally, the female staff had no opinion or were happy (one was not). The male staff members were marginally less satisfied.

The pandemic had some influence on people's workload, as reflected in the comments:

> *"my workload seems to have increased as many more formal meetings."*

> *"If anything, the workload has increased considerably in the past 16 months."*

> *"Work is more intense since March 12 2020 [the date of the first Covid-19 lockdown]"*

4 Evaluating culture, inclusion and belonging

a Provide information on how the department ensures that culture and practices support inclusion and belonging. This should include, but is not limited to, information on how the department actively considers gender equality, and EDI more broadly, in:

- organisation of meeting and events;
- images and text used in department spaces and on the department's website;
- student curricula, pedagogy, and assessment.

Organisation of meetings and events

CSIT organises a variety of school meetings, committees, social events and research seminars. Social events are normally organised for staff at Christmas and in summer. The school aims to promote inclusion by organising social events around staff availability.

School meetings are scheduled for the last Friday of each month at 15:00, and finish by 16:30. These meetings are chaired by a senior member of staff, and all staff are invited to submit agenda items in advance. During the meetings, staff are encouraged to speak freely.

The school organises regular seminars with internal and external speakers. Survey data show that many staff (68% female, 58% male) value gender-balance in seminars, workshops and symposia. However, 42% of females and 32% of males do not feel men

Figure 2.4.1 Meetings and social events. Left: Prof John Morrison, Chair of the SAT, presenting an update at a hybrid school meeting. Right: social event at Christmas 2017

and women are evenly represented among speakers and chairs. Since 2022, staff proposing a male speaker are also strongly encouraged to suggest a female speaker in addition. This has resulted in a better gender balance among speakers (Table 2.4.1).

Table 2.4.1 Gender distribution of speakers at CSIT seminars

Year	Total	Male	Female	Female %
2019	18	13	5	27.8%
2020	11	9	2	18.1%
2021	No seminars due to Covid-19			
2022	13	8	5	38.4%
Total	42	30	12	28.6%

The survey data indicate research staff and PhD students perceived a lack of events and opportunities where they could engage with the school staff. Most networking, job opportunity and professional development events are organised by the research centres (Section 1). Although open to all, centres tend to announce these events only to their members, leaving many unaware of these opportunities. Consequently, not all have the same experience and may feel disconnected from the greater school. This disconnection is accentuated by having PhD students located in centre-specific, access-controlled, laboratories, thus limiting interactions among students working in different areas.

CSIT does not offer formal researcher orientation. Newcomers are not explicitly made aware of the structure of the school, the research centers, and any opportunities that may exist for teaching and laboratory assistance, leading to Action 2.2.9. These issues make it difficult to promote a culture of inclusivity within the school, and may adversely affect the quality of the research by not promoting a culture of multi-disciplinary collaboration (Action 2.4.1).

ACTION 2.4.1: Increase opportunities for researchers to interact

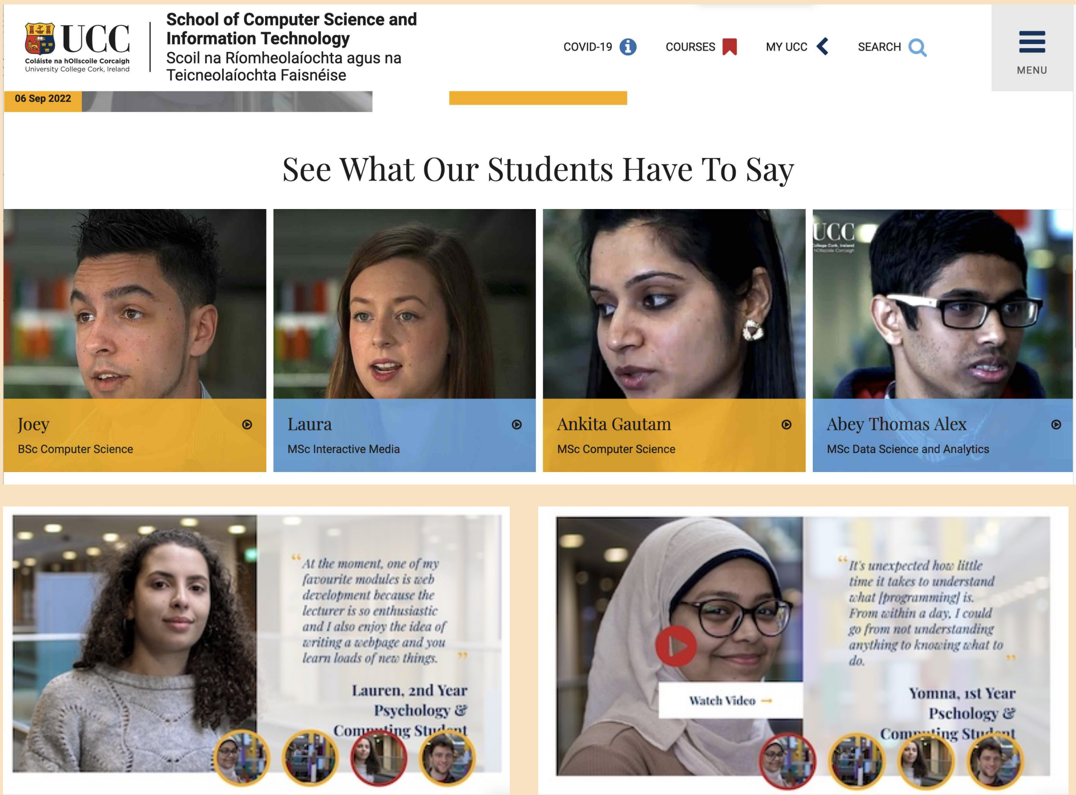
Create opportunities for researchers and PhD students to interact with the school as a whole. ☞

Images and text used in department spaces and on the department's website

The school's website (`https://www.ucc.ie/en/compsci/`) is used to promote its academic programmes and research activities. Graduations, undergraduate events and outreach events are detailed in the news section.

Students from all programmes are invited to share their experiences. Currently, the site includes six testimonials (4F, 1M) of our students.

Figure 2.4.2 Testimonials on the CSIT website



Student curricula, pedagogy, and assessment

The school offers a range of degree programmes (Table 2.4.2), and has two committees concerned with curricula, pedagogy, and assessment: the APCD reviews proposals for new academic programmes and changes proposed to programmes and modules; the Teaching Learning and Student Experience (TLSE) is concerned with the teaching and learning experience.

Before the AS process, no systematic consideration was given to how equality and diversity issues might be used to enhance the curriculum. A first step will be to use

Table 2.4.2 Programme options

Programme	Options
BSc Computer Science	Computer Science, Maths and language electives
BSc Data Science and Analytics	Maths and Statistics electives
BA Psychology and Computing	Optional 9-month work placement
BA Digital Humanities and IT	Optional 9-month work placement; pursue an arts minor subject (e.g. languages, sociology, cultural studies)

school-specific data from the university's biannual EDI Student Survey to uncover the specific needs of students with diverse backgrounds.

The TLSE Committee will use tools developed through the DISCs project (Disciplines Inquiring into Societal Challenges), a collaborative study between UCC, Dublin City University (DCU) and Maynooth University (MU) to develop tools to support the professional development of teaching staff in HE in themes of gender consciousness, interculturalism and community.

We will also participate in UCC EDI-organised briefing sessions on EDI in Teaching & Learning, planned for 2023/24 (Action 2.4.2).

ACTION 2.4.2: Guidelines for addressing needs of students from diverse backgrounds

Provide guidelines for staff on how to address the needs of students from diverse backgrounds. ☞

b Comment and reflect on the department's current understanding of, and capacity to identify and address, issues and opportunities relating to equality grounds in addition to gender, as well as capacity to identify and address intersectional inequalities for staff and students.

School staff and students come from varied ethnic backgrounds and we are just embarking on our journey to build capacity to understand and address inequalities affecting underrepresented groups, and intersectional inequalities. The self-assessment process has revealed a need to build a better awareness of how intersecting identities contribute to experiences of discrimination and disadvantage. We are beginning this work with encouraging all staff to participate in the IHREC[10] eLearning module on 'Equality and Human Rights in the Public Service' and UCC's EDI in Higher Education (HE) programme (including a module on race awareness and anti-racism in HE) (Action 2.4.2).

Of particular importance to the school are two socio-economic factors that, combined with gender, can significantly disadvantage staff and students. The first is income and job insecurity for fixed-term staff. The second is lack of affordable accommodation. The ongoing housing crisis across Ireland, including in Cork, affects staff and students who are renting. Junior academic and research staff, in particular, struggle to secure accommodation. New international staff and students are disproportionally affected. The school has identified the accommodation crisis as a key issue for recruitment and retention of staff at all levels. The HoS is actively advocating at university level for the implementation of measures to mitigate the impact of this crisis.

c Provide information on the department's culture as it relates to gender equality and, where relevant, EDI more broadly, by presenting consultation findings by gender and staff category on the following areas:

- values and traditions of the department;
- formal and informal structures and interactions that characterise the working and learning environment of the department, including leadership practices and behaviours;
- negative practices and behaviours and how these are managed by the department;
- flexible working opportunities in the department;
- management of, and attitudes towards, family leave in the department.

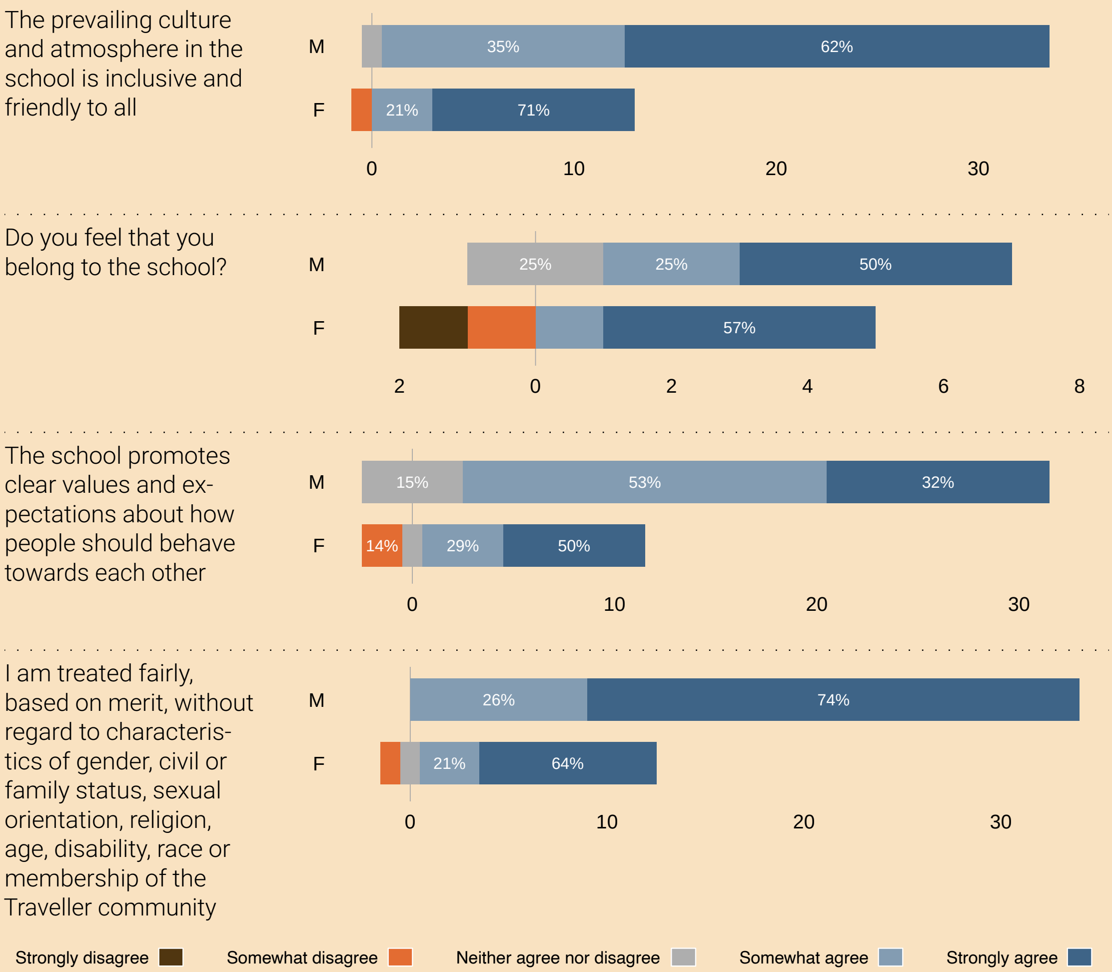
Where data suggests opportunity for improvement, comment and reflect. This should include reflection on any gaps between institution-level policy and practice in the department, including if the institution's approach meets the requirements of department staff.

Values and traditions of the department

There is strong collegiality within the school. The survey data (Figure 2.4.3) show most staff feel they belong and included. There are clear values and expectations on how people should behave towards each other. Staff also believe they are treated

[10] Irish Human Rights and Equality Commission, https://www.ihrec.ie/

Figure 2.4.3 Culture, belonging, values and fairness at CSIT



fairly, without regard to gender, civil or family status, sexual orientation, religion, age, disability, race or membership of the Traveller community.

All staff are invited to school social activities. The school supports various social events for students and staff. For example, several online quiz nights were organised for postgraduate students during the pandemic. The school organises an annual reception for international students attended by the HoS, Programme Directors, and staff from the university's International Office (IO). Other social events include weekly social meetings for researchers, and a well-attended PhD climbing wall event (Figure 2.4.4).

Figure 2.4.4 Social events with students and members of CSIT

Formal and informal structures and interactions characterising the department’s working and learning environment, including leadership practices and behaviours

New staff are assigned a mentor for orientation and to provide guidance on academic career development.

The school supports staff and students in grant and scholarship application (Section 2) and communicates and encourages female-targeted students’ scholarships (e.g., Google stipend) (Section 1).

The HoS recently introduced strategies to support minorities in our international student cohort. For example, establishing an international student mentor role to advise international students on academic and non-academic matters.

In 2023, the school accepted 3 Ukranian student refugees.

Negative practices and behaviours and their management by the department

No specific negative behaviour by staff or students was reported in either the survey or focus groups. Nevertheless, it is school policy to act in accordance with university policy to address any such behaviour, should it arise.

Survey data (Figure 2.4.5) indicate that if witnessing others being unfairly treated, they would mostly feel comfortable reporting it. While the vast majority of staff can identify a safe person to report unfair treatment in the school, a minority of staff feel reporting unfair treatment could affect their career. The reasons behind these answers will be explored in the progress review undertaken by the EDIIC in Year 3 (Action 1.3.3).

Flexible working opportunities in the department

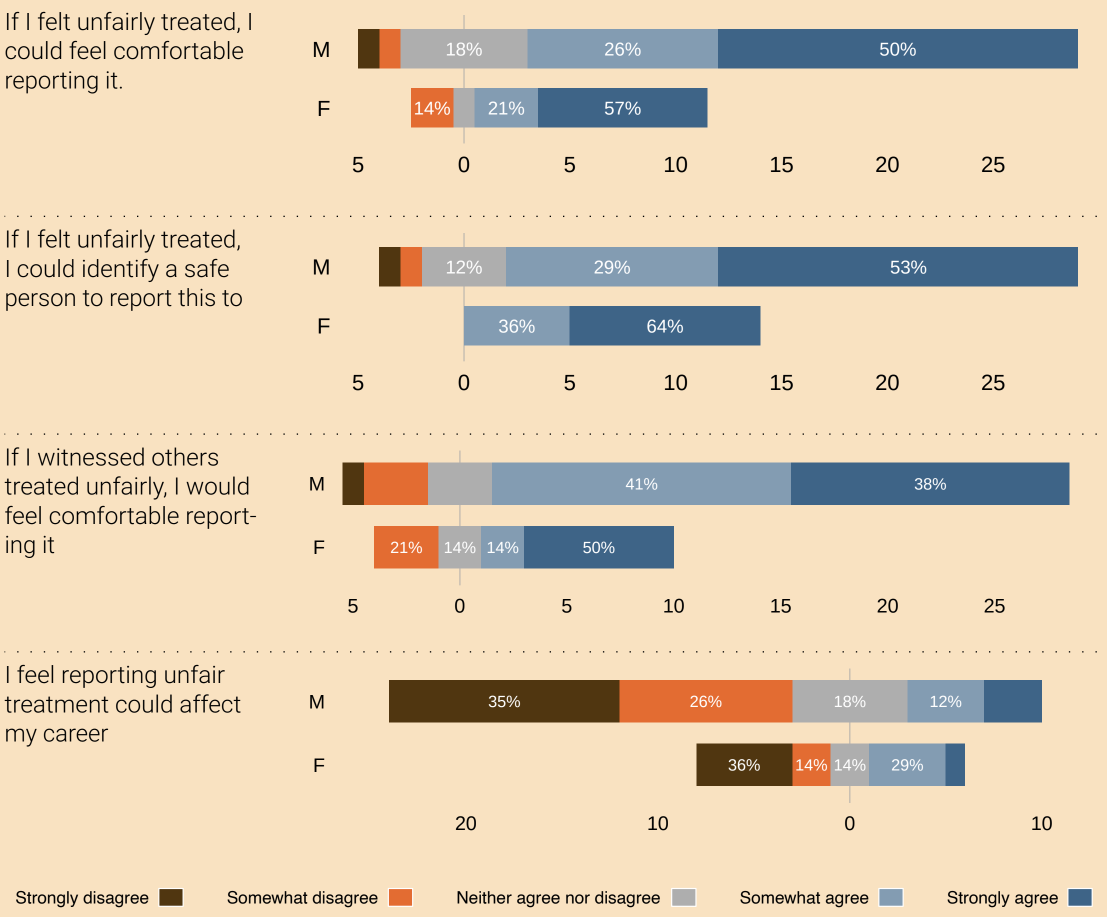
The school currently supports flexible working for all staff. Most staff are facilitated to work from home under the Pilot Blended Working Policy, subject to the nature of their job. The PMS staff focus group and the staff survey indicated strong support for blended working to continue. Staff want the university to provide a clear and transparent policy (Action 2.4.3) and that every effort should be made to maximise flexibility at school level.

> **ACTION 2.4.3: Flexible working**
>
> Implement university policies with regard to blended working and working hours as flexibly as possible, taking account of the requirements of the role. ☞

The school's reception is open daily from 9:00 to 17:00. This limits some PMS staff from availing of flexible start and finish times. Many working arrangements are agreed with line managers subject to university policy. Some academics may indicate preferences for certain time slots for laboratory sessions, though room and student availability must be considered.

Staff in focus groups reported they felt comfortable discussing flexible working arrangements with their line manager. Survey data show most staff are confident of a positive outcome (86% females and 85.7% male agree/strongly agree). Researchers,

Figure 2.4.5 Dealing with unfair treatment



in particular, feel comfortable discussing work life balance issues with their PI (86% females and 100% male agree/strongly agree).

Management of, and attitudes towards, family leave in the department

Table 2.4.3 reports various types of family-related leave during 2017-2020 by CSIT staff. Family leave policies are determined by the university but the school is responsible for arranging cover. It was noted that UCC currently requires staff to have a minimum of six months service to qualify for paid maternity leave. Action 5.5.6 in the *UCC Institutional Bronze Application 2019* addresses this issue:

Table 2.4.3 Leave taken during 2017-2020

Year	Position	Type of leave	Days
2017/18	Research support officer	Parental	6
	Laboratory manager	Parental	19
	Executive Assistant	Parental	4
	Senior research fellow	Paternity	10
	Researcher	Paternity	10
2018/19	Research support officer	Parental	2.5
	Lecturer	Paid maternity	78
2019/20	Lecturer	Paid maternity	52
	Lecturer	Unpaid maternity	18

UCC INSTITUTIONAL ATHENA SWAN BRONZE AWARD ACTION 5.5.6

Review the gender impact of the requirement for 26 weeks continuous service in order to be eligible for paid UCC maternity leave.

The academic focus group reported a supportive environment for colleagues taking maternity and paternity leave; two colleagues returning from maternity leave and long-term medical leave were offered a reduction in teaching for the first semester on return. Participants commended both the current and previous Heads of School for their support for leave-takers. No formal backfill policies exist at the university level for leave other then for maternity and sick leave.

> *"so it's up to the Head of School to try and find a way to cover your classes [and] reduce [your] teaching load for that semester."*

In the absence of an institutional commitment, Heads of School carry a responsibility that some focus group participants felt to be unreasonable. This ad-hoc arrangement means that leave-takers are dependent on the goodwill of the HoS and puts increased demand on the goodwill of colleagues to cover during a period of leave. Leave-takers can feel a sense of responsibility and guilt for burdening colleagues with increased workload; this in turn might deter people from taking statutory leave:

> *"You feel bad about [taking leave] because you're basically asking [colleagues] to [cover your] classes ... It's very awkward, and that has nothing to do with the willingness of the Head of School. As I said, [they're] very supportive, but it's all managed informally. They have to try and help you without getting any [support themselves], pretty much."*

The policy for research students states that a pregnant student should notify her supervisor and independently identify options open to her from her funder (Action 2.4.4).

ACTION 2.4.4: Supporting family Leave

Create a school policy for implementing statutory family leave. ☞

5 Department priorities for future action

a Identify the department's key issues relating to gender equality and establish key priorities for action over the next four years:

- Select up to five key priority areas where the department will strive for impact. Selected priorities should be justifiable and based on the quantitative and qualitative evidence presented in Section 2.
- Specific action(s) to support progress in priority areas should be identified.

Select up to five key priority areas where the department will strive for impact. Selected priorities should be justifiable and based on the quantitative and qualitative evidence presented in Section 2. Specific action(s) to support progress in priority areas should be identified.

Challenge The school has no formal structures nor has had discussions relating to a culture of gender equality and diversity.

> **PRIORITY 1**
>
> Develop the governance, structures, policies and procedures to deliver the AS action plan and imbed the AS Ireland Principles in the school. ☞

A first action is to establish a gender balanced EDI Implementation Committee (EDIIC), and appoint a Chair from amongst the senior staff (Action 1.3.1). The committee will have the authority to oversee the implementation of the action plan and develop a positive EDI culture in the school.

Challenge Computer Science is a male-dominated discipline; Priorities 2 and 3 will address the gender imbalance in CSIT staff (23% F) and student (26% F) cohorts.

> **PRIORITY 2**
>
> Increase the ratio of female applicants for staff posts (Academic / Research) to improve gender balance. ☞

> **PRIORITY 3**
>
> Increase the number of female students registered in UG and PG programmes. ☞

Gender imbalance is more pronounced at undergraduate level, particularly in our flagship BScCS programme (14%). The school will survey our UG students to understand what motivated them to study Computer Science (Action 2.1.2). It will enrich opportunities for female students to gain work experience, for example, through internships in the school (Action 2.1.8). Boosting the visibility of successful female researchers, alumni, and professionals will provide role models for new recruits and current students (Action 2.1.6).

The actions associated with this priority area will provide information to improve our future recruitment strategies, deepening the pipeline for research and academic careers in Computer Science.

Challenge Due to the lack of formal Professional Development Reviews (PDR) and mentoring in recent years, more support is required for staff career development and progression. There is a dearth of female academic (9%) and research (17%) staff in the school, with none at senior grades. The school had no permanent female academic staff member until 2017.

> **PRIORITY 4**
> Supporting staff development to further career progression. ☞

The key actions to deliver on this priority include restarting the Performance Development Review System to support staff career development (Actions 2.2.7, 2.2.4). Improved mentoring for interested staff, career training and research funding workshops will be conducted (Actions 2.2.6, 2.2.8).

Challenge Staff would like to see more family-friendly policies, more diversity and inclusivity in staff and student cohorts.

> **PRIORITY 5**
> Promote a culture of inclusivity and belonging. ☞

The key actions under this priority are both inward and outward focused. The inward actions include supporting family / flexible leave and more integration of all research groups in school events (Actions 2.4.4, 2.4.1). The outward facing actions concentrate on ensuring that schools from diverse backgrounds are a focus of attention (Action 2.4.2).

b Outline how the department's gender equality priorities align with the institution's Athena Swan action plan and, where relevant, broader EDI initiatives in the institution and/or department. This should include comment on:

- key institutional actions that have, or will, support the department's progress;
- any gaps in institutional supports for achieving progress and impact in the department.

Comment on key institutional actions that have, or will, support the department's progress

The university bronze Athena Swan application (2019) has supporting actions which the school can leverage.[11] Notably, the university aims to 'Increase the ratio of female applicants for staff posts (Academic / Research) through the following actions. Action 5.1.5 will support our Priority 1:

> **UCC INSTITUTIONAL ATHENA SWAN BRONZE AWARD ACTION 5.1.5**
>
> Strengthening statements of commitment to EDI principles and practice incorporated into the President's welcome information provided to applicant and a target of 40% female applicants for academic post by 2023. ☞

The university commits to improving promotion pathways for senior academic staff (Actions 5.1.3 and 5.1.9). The university's success criterion and outcome is stated as: *"Promotions across the University are at a minimum of 40% female in all SL and Professor Scale 2 calls"*; this, in combination with a planned promotion pathway to Professor Scale 1, is encouraging for CSIT academic staff (Priority 2).

> **UCC INSTITUTIONAL ATHENA SWAN BRONZE AWARD ACTION 5.1.3**
>
> Establish a promotion pathway to Professor Scale 1, drawing on learnings for gender equality implemented in schemes for promotion to SL (Jan 2019) and Prof Scale 2 (Oct 2019) scheme calls (see Action 5.1.4).

> **UCC INSTITUTIONAL ATHENA SWAN BRONZE AWARD ACTION 5.1.4**
>
> Submit applications for professorial appointments to the HEA Senior Academic Leadership Initiative (SALI).

[11] https://www.ucc.ie/en/media/support/edi/athenaswan/AthenaSWANUCCActionPlan2019-2023.pdf

UCC INSTITUTIONAL ATHENA SWAN BRONZE AWARD ACTION 5.1.9

Following the two promotion calls for Senior Lecturer and Professor (Scale 2) in 2019 in the University's revised promotion schemes, review the number and success of female applicants to assess the gender impact of the revise teaching, research and service criteria and their weighting, and provision for and the provision for statutory leave in these schemes.

Action 5.1.6 in the university application addresses the need for recruitment and selection training for recruitment of research staff (Action 2.2.1).

UCC INSTITUTIONAL ATHENA SWAN BRONZE AWARD ACTION 5.1.6

Pilot action in SEFS to require Principal Investigators (PIs) participate in LEAD equality e-learning (including module on recruitment & selection training) prior to submitting for approval a new funding application which involves recruitment of research staff.

Many of the actions under the university 'Supporting and Advancing Careers' will support the school's ambitions in to support our staff develop their careers (Priority 4).

The university's Action 5.5.2 will support the school to ensure that line managers know their responsibilities regarding family related leave and flexible working (Priority 5).

UCC INSTITUTIONAL ATHENA SWAN BRONZE AWARD ACTION 5.5.2

Implement training for new and existing line managers to outline their roles, responsibilities regarding family related leave and flexible working.

Comment on any gaps in institutional supports for achieving progress and impact in the department

The university does not have the same gender imbalance in academic staff (45% F), research staff (53% F) and students (58% F) as experienced in the school, therefore this is not addressed at university level.

3

Action plan

In Section 3, applicants should evidence how they meet Criterion C:

- Action plan to address identified issues

Present the action plan in the form of a table (landscape page format). The plan should cover current initiatives and aspirations for the next four years. Actions, and their measures of success, should be Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant and Time-bound (SMART).

1 Action Plan

Table 3.1.1 on the next page presents an overview of all actions, which are organised by theme. All links are typeset in blue, which means they can be used while reading a soft copy of this document. Actions that appear in Sections 1 and 2 have a link (indicated by ☞) to their respective entry in the Action Plan in the table below; action numbers in the ID column are hyperlinks back to their origin in Section 1 or 2.

Table 3.1.1 UCC School of Computer Science and Information Technology Athena Swan Action Plan

ID	Action	Rationale	Responsibility	Outputs/Milestones	Time Frame	Success measures
		Priority 1: Develop governance structures, policies and procedures to ensure that the Athena Swan Ireland Principles are imbedded in the school				
1.3.1	Establish an EDI Implementation Committee (EDIIC) to progress and monitor the implementation of the AS SAT Action Plan.	A: To imbed the AS principles in the school's culture, governance, policies and procedures and to link with the wider EDI structures within the University.	Head of School	Milestone 1: EDIIC committee established as part of the school governance structure.	Mid 2023	Gender balanced EDIIC Committee established.
		B. The Chair of this committee will engage in ongoing consultation with the Head of School and the UCC EDI Unit to oversee the implementation of the AS action plan, and will sit on the College's AS steering committee.	EDIIC Chair	Milestone 2: EDIIC Chair will monitor and oversee the implementation of the AS action plan.	2023, 2024, 2025, 2026	Actions delivered based on time frame indicated; adjusted as needed.
			EDIIC Chair	Milestone 3: Annual report on implemented and outstanding actions.	2023, 2024, 2025, 2026	
1.3.2	EDIIC Chair to report progress on EDI agenda twice yearly or more often if needed at school meetings.	Ensures that the school is informed of progress with regard to implementation of the AS action plan, increase awareness of Athena Swan Ireland Principles and provide opportunity for feedback.	EDIIC Chair	EDIIC Chair will report at school meetings.	Twice yearly; October, April	The school reports satisfaction with advancement of EDI agenda based on the EDI staff survey in 2025.
1.3.3	Review the impact of AS Implementation Plan in Year 3.	To give staff and students an opportunity to give anonymous feedback on the impact of the AS action plan and to evaluate if the desired cultural changes are being brought about. To afford the EDIIC committee the opportunity to make any necessary mid-course correction.	EDIIC committee	Formal report to the school at the end of 2025.	November 2025	All key cultural metrics improved with respect to the original EDI survey.

ID	Action	Rationale	Responsibility	Outputs/Milestones	Time Frame	Success measures
2.1.1	Put procedures in place to gather and maintain gender specific data on the number of applicants, shortlisted, and appointments in respect to funded PhD positions.	Research Centres and Principal Investigators currently manages these processes and data, but there is no central data source for PhD recruitment. Collating this data will provide a school-level view which will allow us to track trends across the school's PhD students such as differences by gender in completion rates/times.	PhD Programme Director	Milestone 1: A policy defined, approved by the school and implemented.	2023	The school will have enhanced data as detailed in the annual PhD Programme Director's report that will inform strategies to improve gender balance.
			PhD Programme Director	Milestone 2: Annual reports to the EDIIC/school detailing the gender-balance status in the PhD cohort.	December 2023, 2024, 2025, 2026	
		To monitor PhD applications and recruitment data to inform policies and procedures to improve gender balance across this cohort. Currently the percentage of female PhD students range from 33% in 2017-33%, 19% in 2018-28% and 13% in 2019.	PhD Programme Director	Milestone 3: Database tracking gendered PhD progress and completions.	2023	
2.1.5	Develop guidelines to inform the future production of gender-proof advertisements, materials, and visuals that are gender positive, inclusive, and welcoming of diversity.	The way the school presents itself influences how prospective staff and students from all genders and backgrounds evaluate the school as a place to work and study. As CS is a male dominated discipline, it tends to attract fewer female staff and students. Attracting female applicants at all levels remains a key challenge: Percentage female applicants to: 1) academic positions averages 19% over past 3 years; 2) research posts, 20%; 2) female UG registered, 24%; 3) PhD students registered, 12%.	Ad-hoc working group appointed by the Head of School	Milestone 1: Develop guidelines and training for staff on how to gender proof advertising, website, communications etc. for staff and student recruitment. Tools such as Gender Decoder, e.g. `https://capd.mit.edu/resources/gender-decoder/` may be used. Unconscious bias training amongst others will also be implemented.	2023	100% of advertisements, all future materials and visuals follow the guidelines.
			Programme Directors	Milestone 2: all prospectus and web materials revamped to align with gender proof guidelines.	2024	
			EDIIC	Milestone 3: Annual verification compliance with gender-proofed guidelines.	December 2024, 2025, 2026	

ID	Action	Rationale	Responsibility	Outputs/Milestones	Time Frame	Success measures
2.2.5	Include an invitation in recruitment adverts for applicants to provide an appropriate leave statement to be considered by a selection committee.	During discussions in working and focus groups, a number of staff mentioned that there is no opportunity in job applications to include Covid-19 or family related leave statements to explain career gaps due to caring responsibilities. As this disproportionally affects women, applicants for academic, research, and professional and management posts should be able to provide relevant leave statements.	Head of School, School Manager	Guidelines will be created and communicated to the school on how provide allowance for relevant leave statements.	2023	All advertisements will contain an invitation to candidates to provide a relevant leave statement.
2.2.9	Create a policy, outlining a set of defined opportunities and an application procedures to allow researchers to participate in the specified academic activities.	From the focus group, research staff were unclear about opportunities to participate in tutoring, lecturing and other academic duties in the school.	Head of School and School Manager	Policy and application form for researcher participation in stated opportunities.	2024	10% of researchers taking up one or more of the opportunities defined in the policy.
2.2.10	Review the school workload model for academic staff.	45% of academic staff expressed dissatisfaction with the current workload model used in the school and belief it to be unfair.	Head of School	The school workload model for academic staff will be reviewed to determine any source of dissatisfaction.	2024; 2026	Sources of dissatisfaction under the control of the school will be addressed, where possible. Staff satisfaction will be determined using the EDI annual survey in 2025, aiming to increase staff satisfaction by 25%.

ID	Action	Rationale	Responsibility	Outputs/Milestones	Time Frame	Success measures
2.3.1	Provide guidelines for advertisements for research PMS posts.	The research PMS templates currently used by the university for research recruitment are generic and used for both post-doctoral researchers and research support staff (PMS roles). The templates require experience not relevant to a research support role, such as requesting publication records. This is likely to deter some candidates due to misinterpretation of the role. This drawback in the recruitment process has been highlighted by school PIs and corroborated by recent research PMS recruits.	Head of School, School Manager	Guidelines for advertisements of research posts, and in particular research support posts, that provide practical advice on tailoring the duties and responsibilities associated with the research post.	2023	Increased number of suitable applicants for PMS research posts, compared to 2020.
2.4.3	Implement university policies with regard to blended working and working hours as flexibly as possible, taking account of the requirements of the role.	The introduction of blending working during the Covid-19 pandemic initiated the introduction of a UCC blended pilot working policy. Staff require a clear and transparent articulation of this policy and how it is implemented in the school.	Head of School, line managers	A document outlining the implementation of university policies around blended working and flexible working hours at the school level, taking into consideration the requirements of different roles.	Mid 2023, and updated as university policy evolves.	In the EDI survey 2025, staff report that the school implementation of the university policy is clear and transparent.

ID	Action	Rationale	Responsibility	Outputs/Milestones	Time Frame	Success measures
		Priority 2: Increase ratio of female applicants for staff posts (Academic/ Research) to improve staff gender in these cohorts				
2.2.1	Create a school policy on research recruitment.	All staff engaged in recruitment for academic posts must have had recruitment training, however, this is not a requirement for research recruitment. Moreover, there has been no requirement for gender-balanced committees for research recruitment. In fact, the survey data suggests that these committees have not always been gender-balanced (19% F, on average). Therefore, to align research recruitment and academic recruitment procedures, the school will introduce a new policy to cover staff training and to formalise guidelines for the operation of research recruitment committees.	Research Committee	A school policy on research recruitment, created and approved by the school.	2024	All staff engaged in research recruitment have received appropriate training. Research Recruitment Committees with be gender-balanced. Aspiring to 40% female participation, where practicable.
2.2.2	Improve the advertising text for staff positions to make it more appealing to females.	Attracting female applicants at all levels remains a key challenge as shown by the limited number of applicants. The percentage female applicants for academic positions averages 27% over past 3 years.	Head of School, Centre Directors and PIs	Milestone 1: Gender-proofed advertising. See also Action 2.1.5. Target a wide range of relevant channels to disseminate advertising material, such as Women in AI and IEEE Women in Engineering network.	2023	Increase the percentage of female applicants for academic posts from an average of 27% to 40% by 2026. Increase the percentage of female applicants research staff from 20% to 40% by 2026
			Head of School, School Manager.	Milestone 2: A record of the percentage of female applicants for academic positions.	2023, 2024, 2025, 2026.	

ID	Action	Rationale	Responsibility	Outputs/Milestones	Time Frame	Success measures
2.2.3	Actively target suitable female academics and researchers to apply for vacant school posts.	The survey data reveals that only 27% of applicants for academic post, and 20% for research posts, have been female in the period from 2017 to 2020. We will actively target high-quality female applicants and will engage with targeted gender equality funding initiatives such as the SALI Professorships (See also UCC's Institutional Action 5.1.4)	Head of School, Centre Directors and PIs.	A record of the percentage of female applicants for academic positions.	2023, 2024, 2025, 2026	The number of female applicants for academic (27%) and research (20%) posts will be increased to 40% by 2026, to align with university targets.
Priority 3: Increase number of female students registered in UG and PG programmes						
2.1.2	Survey existing UG females to assess what influenced their decision to study CS (first years), their experience with their programme (middle years) and to gauge attitudes and perceptions towards research/academic careers (final years).	A detailed understanding of perceptions of our courses and discipline among females is key to ensuring any interventions planned are rooted in reality. Attracting female applicants to UG programmes is a global challenge: Percentage females registered on UG programmes is - 24%; but lower for our flagship BSc Computer Science - 14% and BSc Data Science and Analytics - 20%. This will provide key insight in the lack of progression of female undergraduates to PG study.	Programme Directors	Survey data will provide information that can influence our recruitment strategy with aim of attracting more females.	2023; 2025	A female UG participation in the survey of 75%
2.1.4	Review existing marketing materials and outreach activities to assess their effectiveness to attract female school leavers to choose computer science.	Current activities aim to promote gender balance, by including females in web photos, videos, on open day stands, in brochures etc., however, there has been no follow up activity to determine the effectiveness of these measures.	Ad-hoc working group, established by the Head of School.	The school have a set of guidelines for producing more effective female-friendly marketing materials and outreach activities.	2023	The percentage females entering BScCS and BScDSA will have increased from 14% to 20% and from 20% to 25%, respectively, by 2026.

ID	Action	Rationale	Responsibility	Outputs/Milestones	Time Frame	Success measures
2.1.6	Boost visibility of female researchers, alumnae and professionals and highlight their work to provide role models for female UGs and prospective students.	Examples of successful females in the discipline will help to project computer science as a more female-friendly subject.	Outreach committee, seminar series coordinator	Seminars and talks and video presentations by high-profile female computing professionals.	2023	25% of seminar presenters will be female at school run seminars.
2.1.7	Appoint a mentor for female UG students to provide guidance and encouragement and to support their academic and career development.	Given the under representation of female undergraduate student (BSc Computer Science 14%); BSc Data Science and Analytics (20%), the school will advise and encourage female undergraduate students to avail of opportunities to support their career development and act as role models to attract more females into our programmes.	Head of School	A programme of activities and supports for female undergraduates, such as, internships, workshops, and networking opportunities.	2023	Increase percentage of females entering BSc Computer Science to 20% and BSc Data Science and Analytics to 25% over the lifetime of the award.
2.1.8	Provide female undergraduates with internship opportunities in the school's research centers.	In recent years, no female has progressed from CSIT undergraduate studies to postgraduate. In fact, in the past 5 years, only two students have done this, both male. By offering a number of female-only internships on an annual basis, it is hoped that more females will become familiar with research as a career option and will subsequently progress from undergraduate to postgraduate studies in CSIT.	Head of School and Research Centre Directors	A female-only internship programme is established.	2024, 2025, 2026	At least two female-internship opportunities are made available and taken-up on an annual basis.

ID	Action	Rationale	Responsibility	Outputs/Milestones	Time Frame	Success measures
			Priority 4: Improved staff development to support for career progression			
2.2.4	Research supervisors and PIs will actively mentor and encourage postdoctoral researchers towards academic careers, by helping them to create a personal development plan.	The pathway from postgraduate to career academic is challenging. A personal development plan can be a useful tool in helping aspiring academics to come to grips with the prerequisites of an academic post; and mentoring for the production of such a plan can mean the difference between success and failure. Given the underrepresentation of females in the discipline, it is felt that such mentoring could be extremely valuable to female researchers, since the percentage of female applicants to academic positions is far less than that of males. From the survey data, only 38% of postdoctoral researchers currently have access to adequate mentoring.	Head of School, Research Centre Directors	A mentoring programme for creating a personal development plan is in place.	2023, 2024, 2025, 2026	80% of postdoctoral researchers have a PDP, as measured by the EDI survey conducted in 2025.
2.2.6	Create a mentoring and support scheme for academic staff who seek promotion.	From the survey data, only 33% (50% F, 17% M) of academic staff reported access to adequate training and mentoring, to help them to navigate the promotion process.	Head of School	A workshop for staff seeking promotion and a mentor appointed to interested staff following the PDRS review.	2023, 2024, 2025, 2026	100% of staff are satisfied with mentoring scheme as measured by the EDI survey in 2025.
2.2.7	Restart Performance Development Review System (PDRS) for all staff in the school.	The school has not operated a PDRS for over 5 years, although it was due to restart prior to the restrictions imposed by the pandemic in March 2020. In 2021, a new Head of School was appointed and restarting this process is a priority to support staff development.	Head of School, Line Managers.	The PDRS in operation.	2023, 2025	Relevant staff will have taken part in the PDRS by the end of 2023.

ID	Action	Rationale	Responsibility	Outputs/Milestones	Time Frame	Success measures
2.2.8	Create a programme to support school staff with research funding applications.	The school has an excellent track record in attracting research funding, however, this is centered around a small number of senior staff. The survey revealed several issues in relation to the opportunities to apply for funding, the support from the school in the process, but also for those whose applications were unsuccessful, and support from university.	Research Committee	Workshop to support interested staff navigate the funding process and a peer-review process to appraise applications before submission.	2023, 2024, 2025, 2026.	100% of applicants are satisfied with the supports provide by the school for research funding applications, as measured by the EDI staff survey in 2025.
2.3.2	Provide PMS staff with regular opportunities for professional career development.	School PMS staff expressed a desire, in the EDI survey and focus group, to develop skills beyond the remit of their existing roles. A range of measures were discussed including, committee membership, training, deputising where appropriate and the taking on of additional responsibilities.	PMSS Line Managers	A record of occurrences of opportunities offered.	2023, 2024, 2025, 2026	A minimum of 2 opportunities are offered annually and school PMS staff record satisfaction with same as part of the EDI survey in 2025.
			Priority 5: Promote a culture of inclusivity and belonging			
2.1.3	Revise school outreach programme to increase the number of visits to second-level schools with students from diverse backgrounds.	Discussions in focus groups highlighted the need to increase diversity in the secondary school outreach programme. Members felt strongly that increasing diversity in education promotes a culture of inclusion and leads to better outcomes for students from minority-backgrounds.	Outreach Committee	A list of schools identified as having students with diverse backgrounds.	2023, 2024, 2025, 2026	At least 20% of secondary school visited annually were to those schools identified as having students with diverse backgrounds by 2026.

ID	Action	Rationale	Responsibility	Outputs/Milestones	Time Frame	Success measures
2.4.1	Create opportunities for researchers and PhD students to interact with the school as a whole.	During focus group sessions researchers and PhD students expressed a feeling of separation from the school. They believed that a lack of school-wide events reduced opportunities for collaboration and inclusion.	Research Committee and Director of PhD Programme.	School research forum organised annually Social event organised after the annualy PhD review day for PhD students and staff. Invitations issued to reserachers to attend the monthly school coffee morning. On arrival, new research staff and PhD students are introduced to the staff via the weekly "Monday Morning News" email.	2023, 2024, 2025, 2026	75% of researcher staff and PhD students report feeling included in the EDI staff survey in 2025.
2.4.2	Provide guidelines for staff on how to address the needs of students from diverse backgrounds.	We are not aware of the needs of our students from diverse backgrounds nor have we systematically engaged with issues of equality and diversity to enhance student experience within the curriculum.	TLSE Committee	Milestone 1: Determine needs of students with diverse backgrounds using the biannual EDI Student Survey	2023	10% of academic staff participating in the EDI/IHREC briefings and training; and 5% of academic staff engaging with the DISC toolset in 2024.
			TLSE Committee	Milestone 2: Explore and exploit appropriate tools and training to enhance the student experience.	2024	
			TLSE Committee	Milestone 3: Participate in the IHREC eLearning module on 'Equality and Human Rights in the Public Service' and the UCC's EDI in HE programme	2024	

ID	Action	Rationale	Responsibility	Outputs/Milestones	Time Frame	Success measures
2.4.4	Create a school policy for implementing statutory family leave.	Feedback from the staff survey and focus groups reported a lack of clarity on how family leave is managed in the school. Researchers described challenges requesting family leave and principal investigators voiced concern over different approaches to funding family leave by different research funders.	Head of School, Line Manager	A policy outlining how family leave arrangements are managed by the school within the constraints of statutory obligations.	2024	Staff report clarity and understanding on how the school implements family leave in the EDI survey of 2025.

Athena Swan Bronze Application
School of Computer Science and Information Technology
University College Cork
December 2022